PRACTICAL ENGLISH GRAMMAR AND VOCABULARY MASTERY

THE FORUM CENTER

TÀI LIỆU LÝ THUYẾT

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Bản quyền thuộc về The Forum Center

How to use this handbook

- Study the book in order if your foundations are weak: sentence structure, noun phrases, articles, and verb forms come before advanced writing or speaking sections.
- Do not only read rules. Say the model sentences aloud, then write new sentences with your own information, daily routines, opinions, or work/study topics.
- When you meet a mistake that you often make, copy it into an error log. Write the wrong sentence, the corrected sentence, and one new example.
- Use the writing sections to build paragraphs and short answers. Use the speaking sections to practise chunks, follow-up questions, and repair strategies.
- For vocabulary, learn words in groups: word family, common collocations, prepositions, typical sentence pattern, and a personal example.
- Return to the common-mistake tables often. Vietnamese learners usually improve fastest when they stop translating word by word and start noticing English patterns.

Core principle

• Do not study grammar and vocabulary as separate subjects. Use grammar to build real sentences and use vocabulary in fixed phrases and natural collocations.

Book map

Part	Title	What you will build
I	Thinking in English, not translated Vietnamese	How English sentences work; what Vietnamese learners usually miss; how to build clear word order.
II	Grammar that controls time, meaning, and accuracy	Verb patterns, tenses, questions, conditionals, passive voice, and longer sentences.
III	Practical writing	Sentence clarity, paragraph structure, linking, editing, register, and useful written formats.
IV	Practical speaking	Natural conversation patterns, opinions, storytelling, repair strategies, and pronunciation habits that affect grammar and vocabulary.
V	Vocabulary mastery	Word families, collocations, phrasal verbs, topic vocabulary, false friends, and register control.
VI	Practice and reference	Translation drills, correction drills, study plans, essential tables, and self-edit tools.

Why English feels difficult for Vietnamese learners

English and Vietnamese organise meaning differently. If you understand the differences clearly, many repeated mistakes stop feeling random. The table below shows the contrasts that most often affect writing and speaking.

Feature	Difference	Practical result
Subjects	Vietnamese can drop the subject when the context is clear; English usually needs an explicit subject.	Say “It is raining,” not just “Is raining.”
Verb tense	Vietnamese often shows time with adverbs like đã, đang, sẽ; English usually marks time on the verb too.	Do not rely only on yesterday/now/tomorrow. Change the verb form as well.
Articles	Vietnamese has no article system like a, an, the.	Vietnamese learners often forget articles or use the too often.
Plural forms	Vietnamese nouns do not change like book/books in the same way English nouns do.	Listen for final -s and write plural forms carefully.
Be	Vietnamese often says a sentence without an equivalent of am/is/are.	Do not write “She very friendly.” Write “She is very friendly.”
Question form	Vietnamese makes questions with particles and voice change; English changes word order or uses do/does/did.	Practise “Do you…?”, “Are you…?”, “Have you…?”
Adjective order	Vietnamese adjectives often come after the noun; English adjectives usually come before the noun.	Say “a useful book,” not “a book useful.”
Final sounds	Vietnamese speakers often drop final consonants in fast speech.	Missing final sounds can hide grammar: works/worked/books/asked.
Direct translation	Some natural Vietnamese expressions become unnatural in English if translated word for word.	Use chunks such as “turn on the light,” not “open the light.”

High-priority habits

- Always write the subject and verb first.
- Check articles and plural forms before you check difficult vocabulary.
- Learn words as chunks, not as single translations.
- Read your English aloud; speaking reveals grammar gaps very quickly.

A simple daily practice cycle

Step	What to do
1. Input	Read or listen to one short, useful text and underline patterns you can reuse.
2. Notice	Identify one grammar point and three collocations in that text.
3. Say	Read the model sentences aloud, then say two personal versions.
4. Write	Write five sentences or one short paragraph using the patterns.
5. Edit	Check subject + verb, tense, noun phrase, preposition, word choice.
6. Review	Add mistakes and useful chunks to your notebook or flashcards.

PART I

Thinking in English, not translated Vietnamese

Build sentence foundations, word order, noun control, and the patterns that Vietnamese learners need first.

1. The shortest complete English sentence

Practical goal: *Build sentences that are complete, grammatical, and easy to understand in both speech and writing.*

Every useful piece of English starts with a complete thought. In normal English, a complete sentence needs a subject and a verb. Sometimes the verb is an action verb, and sometimes it is a form of be. Vietnamese often allows shorter answers and topic-based fragments when the context is clear, but English requires a clearer sentence frame more often. This is why many Vietnamese learners produce lines such as "Very difficult" or "Because too expensive" when they should produce a full sentence.

A good first habit is to check three things: Who or what is the sentence about? What is happening or being described? Is the idea finished? If the answer to any of these questions is no, the sentence probably needs more work. Complete sentences matter in conversation because they make your meaning clear; they matter in writing because incomplete sentences reduce accuracy and coherence.

Vietnamese learner alert/Lưu ý cho người Việt

- English usually needs a visible subject: I, you, we, they, he, she, it, this, the problem, my friend, the chart, the company.
- The verb can be an action verb (work, study, change) or a linking verb (be, seem, become, look, feel).
- A phrase is not always a sentence. "In my hometown" is only a phrase. "I grew up in my hometown" is a sentence.
- Fragments often appear after because, although, when, if, and while. Add the main clause.

Core patterns

Pattern	Use	Example
Subject + verb	basic complete idea	Prices increased.
Subject + be + adjective	describe a state or quality	The room is quiet.
Subject + be + noun	identify or classify	My brother is an engineer.
Subject + verb + object	show an action affecting something	She finished her report.
There is/are + noun	introduce something	There are many small cafés nearby.
It is + adjective + to-infinitive	evaluate an action	It is useful to review daily.

Useful speaking examples

- I work in sales, but I am studying data analysis at night.
- My English is not perfect yet, but it is improving.
- There are too many motorbikes on this street in the morning.
- It is hard to stay confident when I forget a word.

Useful writing examples

- The main reason is that public transport is still limited in many areas.
- There are several factors that explain this change.
- It is important to separate opinion from evidence in formal writing.
- The chart shows a gradual increase over the ten-year period.

Common mistakes and better English

Common mistake	Better English	Why
Very convenient for students.	It is very convenient for students.	English needs a subject and a verb.
Because the price too high.	Because the price is too high, many people delay the purchase.	A because-clause is not a full sentence by itself.
In my city many coffee shops.	There are many coffee shops in my city.	Use there is/are to introduce existence.
My father engineer.	My father is an engineer.	Use be to connect subject and noun.

Mini drill

1. Turn this fragment into a sentence: very useful for beginners
2. Turn this fragment into a sentence: because I was tired
3. Turn this fragment into a sentence: in my neighbourhood
4. Turn this note into a sentence: my sister/good at/design
5. Turn this note into a sentence: many students/worry about/tuition fees

Possible answers

1. It is very useful for beginners.
2. Because I was tired, I went to bed early.
3. There are several small parks in my neighbourhood.
4. My sister is good at design.
5. Many students worry about tuition fees.

Upgrade tip

• When you edit your writing, underline the subject and circle the verb in each sentence. This simple check immediately catches many Vietnamese-style fragments.

2. Word order: English is less flexible than Vietnamese

Practical goal: *Put words in a natural order so your sentence sounds English, not translated.*

English depends heavily on word order. The subject usually comes before the verb. Adjectives usually come before the noun. Adverbs of frequency usually come before the main verb but after be. Time and place often come later in the sentence, although some adverbials can move for emphasis. Vietnamese can be more flexible in information order because meaning is supported by context. English can become unclear quickly if words appear in the wrong place.

For Vietnamese learners, word order problems often appear in three areas: adjective position, adverb position, and clause position. The fastest way to improve is to memorise sentence frames, not isolated rules. Think in blocks: subject + verb + object + place + time, or subject + be + adjective, or there is/are + noun + place.

Vietnamese learner alert

- Put adjectives before nouns: a difficult exam, an interesting book, a useful website.
- Put adverbs of frequency before the main verb but after be: I usually wake up early; She is often late.
- Put enough after adjectives but before nouns: good enough, enough time.
- Long noun phrases should stay close to the noun they describe.

Core patterns

Pattern	Use	Example
Adjective + noun	describe the noun naturally	a practical guide
be + adverb of frequency	frequency with be	He is usually calm.
adverb of frequency + main verb	frequency with other verbs	They often practise together.
verb + object + place + time	common neutral order	We held the meeting online yesterday.
linker + clause, main clause	show logical relation	Although it was late, she kept working.
main clause + because/when/if-clause	keep main idea first	I stayed home because it was raining.

Useful speaking examples

- I usually review new words on the bus.
- My office is quite far from my home, so I leave early.
- We had a really useful discussion after class yesterday.
- She is often nervous before presentations.

Useful writing examples

- The survey reveals a clear difference between urban and rural respondents.
- Students frequently struggle with article use in the early stages of learning.
- Although the change was gradual, the overall trend was upward.
- This approach provides a more practical solution for working adults.

Common mistakes and better English

Common mistake	Better English	Why
a car red	a red car	Adjectives usually come before nouns in English.
I go often there	I often go there	Adverbs of frequency usually go before the main verb.
She speaks English very well in meetings usually	She usually speaks English very well in meetings	Put the frequency adverb earlier.
I bought yesterday a new laptop	I bought a new laptop yesterday	Object usually comes before the time expression.

Mini drill

6. Reorder the words: usually/I/after dinner/practise/pronunciation
7. Reorder the words: report/an/informative/this/is
8. Reorder the words: because/stayed home/I/was sick/I
9. Reorder the words: often/are/my parents/busy/at the weekend
10. Reorder the words: bought/she/last month/a useful dictionary

Possible answers

1. I usually practise pronunciation after dinner.
2. This is an informative report.
3. I stayed home because I was sick.
4. My parents are often busy at the weekend.
5. She bought a useful dictionary last month.

Upgrade tip

• When a sentence sounds unnatural, read it aloud and ask: what comes first in real English—the description, the action, or the time? Usually English wants a stable frame before extra details.

3. Nouns, articles, plurals, and quantity

Practical goal: *Use noun forms correctly and stop making article and plural mistakes that are extremely common among Vietnamese learners.*

Nouns look simple, but they cause a high number of errors in both writing and speaking. English nouns can be countable or uncountable, singular or plural, specific or non-specific. That means you often need to decide three things at the same time: Do I need a/an/the? Do I need a plural form? Do I need a quantity word such as much, many, a little, a few, some, or several?

Vietnamese does not force the same decisions. Because of that, many learners write sentences such as “I need informations,” “teacher should give student feedback,” or “the life is difficult” when no article is needed. If you master noun patterns, your English immediately looks more mature and accurate.

Vietnamese learner alert/Lưu ý cho người Việt

• Use a/an for one non-specific countable noun: a phone, an hour, a university, an MBA.
• Use the when the listener/reader can identify the thing: the teacher we met, the chart, the internet, the city centre.
• Most singular countable nouns need an article or determiner: a book, my book, this book, one book—not just book.
• Uncountable nouns do not usually take plural -s: information, advice, furniture, equipment, homework, research.

Core patterns

Pattern	Use	Example
a/an + singular countable noun	one item, non-specific	a good idea
the + noun	specific item already known	the main issue
plural noun without article	general meaning	Students need feedback.
uncountable noun without plural -s	mass or abstract noun	Research takes time.
many/few + countable plural	quantity with countable nouns	many options
much/little + uncountable noun	quantity with uncountable nouns	little time

Useful speaking examples

- I need some advice about choosing a course.
- There are several problems with the current system.
- The information on that website is not very clear.
- I bought a new backpack because the old one was broken.

Useful writing examples

- Students require access to reliable information and practical support.
- The report identifies three major causes of the decline.
- Many young people face financial pressure at university.
- This equipment is expensive, but it improves efficiency.

Common mistakes and better English

Common mistake	Better English	Why
I need many advices.	I need a lot of advice.	Advice is uncountable.
Teacher should help student.	Teachers should help students.	General plural nouns are better here.
She gave me an information.	She gave me some information.	Information is uncountable.
I went to the school by bus yesterday to visit my cousin who studies there.	I went to school by bus yesterday to visit my cousin who studies there.	Go to school often has a general institutional meaning without the.
Life in the Vietnam is changing quickly.	Life in Vietnam is changing quickly.	Country names usually do not take the.
I bought book.	I bought a book.	Singular countable nouns usually need an article or determiner.

Mini drill

11. Choose the correct form: advice/advices
12. Complete: I bought ___ umbrella and ___ notebook.
13. Complete: Students need ___ feedback to improve.
14. Complete: There are too ___ mistakes in this paragraph.
15. Correct the sentence: My company bought new equipments.

Possible answers

1. advice
2. an umbrella and a notebook
3. feedback
4. many
5. My company bought new equipment.

Upgrade tip

• When you learn a new noun, record four things: countable or uncountable, common article, plural form, and one collocation. Example: advice (uncountable) — useful advice — give advice.

4. Pronouns, possession, and reference

Practical goal: *Refer to people and things clearly, avoid repetition, and use possessive forms naturally.*

Pronouns help English sound smooth, but they also create confusion when the reference is unclear. A strong English sentence makes it easy for the listener or reader to know who he, she, they, it, this, or these refers to. Vietnamese can leave many references implicit, but English prefers clearer tracking, especially in writing.

You also need to master possessive forms because English uses them frequently: my, your, his, her, its, our, their, mine, yours, hers, ours, theirs, and apostrophe-s. Vietnamese learners often mix subject pronouns and possessive adjectives, or overuse of instead of shorter possessive structures.

Vietnamese learner alert/Lưu ý cho người Việt

- Do not confuse subject forms and possessive forms: she/her/hers; they/their/theirs.
- Use it for things, ideas, weather, time, distance, and many impersonal sentences: It is late. It seems useful.
- Use this/these for something psychologically or physically close; that/those for something more distant.
- In writing, repeat the noun if the pronoun could be ambiguous.

Core patterns

Pattern	Use	Example
subject pronoun + verb	name the doer	They agreed quickly.
possessive adjective + noun	show ownership	our plan
noun + 's + noun	compact ownership	Lan's presentation
of + noun	formal or inanimate possession	the result of the survey
this/these + noun	point to something near/current	these challenges
one/ones	avoid repetition of a noun	the cheaper one

Useful speaking examples

- My manager changed her schedule, so our meeting starts later now.
- I like these shoes, but that pair is more comfortable.
- Their office is smaller than ours.
- Lan's idea was simple, but it solved the problem.

Useful writing examples

- This trend suggests that young adults are changing their priorities.
- The company's strategy and its long-term goals are closely connected.
- These findings support the argument presented in the previous section.
- The quality of the data affects the reliability of the conclusion.

Common mistakes and better English

Common mistake	Better English	Why
She forgot she laptop.	She forgot her laptop.	Use the possessive adjective her.
The company changed their strategy and it lost customers.	The company changed its strategy and then lost customers.	Company as a singular organisation often takes its in formal writing.
This problems are serious.	These problems are serious.	Plural noun needs these.
The reason is because they lost their motivation, and this made students disappointed.	The reason is that they lost their motivation, and this made the students disappointed.	Use a clearer reference and avoid reason is because in formal writing.

Mini drill

16. Choose the correct word: she/her report was late.
17. Complete: The company launched a new app, but ___ was not successful.
18. Replace the repeated noun: I prefer the blue shirt, not the black shirt.
19. Correct the sentence: Our team presented our project, and teacher praised we.
20. Choose the correct demonstrative: this/these issues

Possible answers

1. her
2. it
3. I prefer the blue shirt, not the black one.
4. Our team presented our project, and the teacher praised us.
5. these

Upgrade tip

• In speaking, clear reference creates confidence. When you tell a story, name the person once, then use pronouns only when the listener can still follow easily.

5. Adjectives, adverbs, and comparison

Practical goal: *Describe things accurately and stop confusing adjective and adverb forms.*

Adjectives describe nouns; adverbs usually describe verbs, adjectives, or whole clauses. This distinction is basic, but it creates frequent mistakes for Vietnamese learners because Vietnamese often uses one flexible word form in places where English changes the form. Another common problem is comparison: English uses comparative structures very often in both academic and daily English, so you need them for describing changes, making recommendations, and giving opinions.

This chapter also matters because good speaking and writing both depend on precise description. Strong descriptions make your answers sound more natural and your essays more analytical. Instead of saying good again and again, you need patterns such as more reliable, less effective, highly practical, relatively stable, and by far the most useful.

Vietnamese learner alert/Lưu ý cho người Việt

• Use adjectives after be and before nouns: useful advice, the result is useful.
• Use adverbs for most verbs: speak clearly, write carefully, work efficiently.
• Some words are both adjective and adverb or have unusual forms: fast, hard, late, early, well.
• Do not confuse hard and hardly, late and lately, near and nearly.

Core patterns

Pattern	Use	Example
adjective + noun	describe a thing	a clear explanation
be + adjective	describe a state	The lesson is useful.
verb + adverb	describe manner	She explained patiently.
comparative + than	compare two things	This method is faster than the old one.
the + superlative	show the highest degree	the most practical option
as + adjective + as	show equality	It is as important as grammar.

Useful speaking examples

- This route is much faster than the other one in the morning.
- He speaks so softly that I sometimes miss the last word.
- Online lessons are convenient, but face-to-face classes can be more effective.
- That was the most useful piece of feedback I received all week.

Useful writing examples

- The second option appears more cost-effective than the first.
- Overall, the northern region remained relatively stable throughout the period.
- This solution is not only practical but also environmentally friendly.
- Students who revise regularly usually perform better than those who study only before exams.

Common mistakes and better English

Common mistake	Better English	Why
She speaks English very good.	She speaks English very well.	Use the adverb well after a verb.
This is more easier.	This is easier.	Do not use double comparatives.
My hometown is more peaceful than Ho Chi Minh City, especially at night.	My hometown is more peaceful than Ho Chi Minh City, especially at night.	Correct; keep as model of clean comparison.
He is a carefully person.	He is a careful person.	Use the adjective careful before the noun.
I am boring in this topic.	I am bored by this topic/This topic is boring.	Bored describes the person; boring describes the thing.

Mini drill

21. Choose the correct form: quick/quickly — She finished the task ____.
22. Complete: This café is ____ (quiet) than the one near my office.
23. Complete: It was the ____ (useful) lesson of the course.
24. Correct the sentence: My mother cooks very delicious.
25. Choose the correct word: interested/interesting — I am ____ in language learning.

Possible answers

1. quickly
2. quieter
3. most useful
4. My mother cooks very well./My mother makes very delicious food.
5. interested

Upgrade tip

• In writing, avoid overusing very + adjective. Upgrade with adverbs such as highly, relatively, particularly, increasingly, slightly, remarkably, and extremely when the meaning fits.

6. Prepositions in practical English

Practical goal: *Use the most frequent prepositions correctly in time, place, movement, and fixed expressions.*

Prepositions cause frustration because they are partly logical and partly fixed. Some prepositions show a clear relationship in time or space: on Monday, at 7 p.m., in the kitchen, from home to work. Others belong to common word partnerships: interested in, depend on, good at, responsible for, arrive at, arrive in. Vietnamese learners often try to translate directly from Vietnamese, but English preposition choice usually depends on pattern memory.

The practical solution is not to memorise long theoretical lists. Instead, learn prepositions by category and by chunk. Learn not only arrive but arrive at the station, arrive in Hanoi, arrive home. Learn not only interested but interested in, interested in science, interested in learning how people think.

Vietnamese learner alert/Lưu ý cho người Việt

• Time: at + exact time, on + day/date, in + month/year/long period.
• Place: at + point, in + enclosed area/city/country, on + surface or line.
• Movement: to, into, onto, from, through, across, along, past.
• Many common errors come from missing or extra prepositions: discuss something, enter a room, request something, marry someone.

Core patterns

Pattern	Use	Example
at + time/place point	exact point	at 6.30; at the station
on + day/surface	days and surfaces	on Friday; on the table
in + period/area	months, years, cities, countries	in 2025; in Da Nang
interested in/good at/afraid of	adjective + preposition	good at maths
depend on/belong to/focus on	verb + preposition	focus on the key issue
from ... to ...	range or movement	from home to work

Useful speaking examples

- I arrived at the airport early, but the flight was still delayed.
- She is really good at explaining difficult ideas in simple language.
- I usually work on my laptop in a small café near my apartment.
- We walked across the bridge and into the old part of the city.

Useful writing examples

- The decline was most noticeable in the final year of the period.
- The proposal focuses on three areas: cost, access, and long-term impact.
- Many graduates depend on part-time work while they are at university.
- Interest in online learning increased sharply during the pandemic years.

Common mistakes and better English

Common mistake	Better English	Why
I discussed about the problem.	I discussed the problem.	Discuss does not need about.
She married with a doctor.	She married a doctor.	Marry usually takes a direct object.
We arrived to the station.	We arrived at the station.	Arrive at a point; arrive in a city/country.
He is good in English.	He is good at English.	Good at is the normal pattern.
I requested for a refund.	I requested a refund.	Request usually takes a direct object.

Mini drill

26. Complete: I usually study ___ night.
27. Complete: She is interested ___ graphic design.
28. Complete: We travelled ___ Hue ___ Hoi An by car.
29. Correct the sentence: I entered into the room quietly.
30. Choose the best option: at/in/on 2019

Possible answers

1. at night
2. in
3. from Hue to Hoi An
4. I entered the room quietly.
5. in 2019

Upgrade tip

• Build your own pattern notebook with headings such as adjective + preposition, verb + preposition, noun + preposition. This is more useful than learning prepositions in isolation.

PART II

Grammar that controls time, meaning, and accuracy

Master helper verbs, tense choice, questions, verb patterns, passives, conditionals, and other structures that affect both writing and speaking.

7. Be, do, have, and other helper verbs

Practical goal: *Control the helper verbs that make English questions, negatives, and many sentence patterns possible.*

A large part of English grammar depends on helper verbs, also called auxiliary verbs. Vietnamese learners often know the main verbs but still make errors because the helper system is different from Vietnamese. English uses be for identity, description, location, and continuous forms; do for questions, negatives, emphasis, and many common expressions; have for possession, obligations in some patterns, and perfect tenses.

If you do not control helper verbs, even simple English becomes unstable. This is why learners produce sentences such as “Why you late?”, “He not like coffee,” or “I very agree.” Strong control of be, do, and have creates a base for speaking naturally and for writing accurate sentences.

Vietnamese learner alert/Lưu ý cho người Việt

- Use be as the main verb in sentences like She is happy, They are at home, It was difficult.
- Use do/does/did to make questions and negatives when there is no other auxiliary: Do you work here? She does not drive.
- Use have as a main verb for possession and many common expressions: have a car, have breakfast, have trouble sleeping.
- Agree is a normal verb, not an adjective. Say I agree, not I am agree.

Core patterns

Pattern	Use	Example
be + noun/adjective/place	identity, description, location	He is a designer.
do/does/did + subject + base verb	questions	Do you need help?
subject + do/does/did not + base verb	negatives	They do not know.
have/has + noun	possession or experience	She has a meeting.
have + past participle	perfect tense helper	I have finished.
be + verb-ing	continuous tense helper	We are waiting.

Useful speaking examples

- Do you have a few minutes to talk?
- I don't know the exact answer, but I can check it later.
- She is really busy this week because she has two presentations.
- Did you enjoy the workshop yesterday?

Useful writing examples

- The results do not support the first hypothesis.
- Many participants have limited access to formal training.
- The company is currently developing a new payment system.
- This does not mean that the policy is ineffective in every context.

Common mistakes and better English

Common mistake	Better English	Why
Why you are late?	Why are you late?	When be is the main verb, invert be and subject.
He not understand the question.	He does not understand the question.	Use does not + base verb.
I am agree with this idea.	I agree with this idea.	Agree is a verb.
She has finished her work yesterday.	She finished her work yesterday.	Finished yesterday usually needs past simple, not present perfect.

Mini drill

31. Make a question: you/like/spicy food
32. Make a negative sentence: he/understand/the instructions
33. Correct the sentence: My parents very supportive.
34. Complete: She ____ been here before.
35. Correct the sentence: I don't have understand this point.

Possible answers

1. Do you like spicy food?
2. He does not understand the instructions.
3. My parents are very supportive.
4. has
5. I don't understand this point.

Upgrade tip

• When you learn any tense, always learn the helper pattern together with it. For example, present perfect is not only a meaning; it is have/has + past participle.

8. Present simple and present continuous

Practical goal: *Choose correctly between routine/fact meaning and current/temporary meaning.*

These two present forms are among the first tenses that learners study, but they remain a source of error for years. The present simple usually expresses habits, routines, repeated actions, general truths, and states. The present continuous usually expresses something happening now, around now, or in a temporary current period. In Vietnamese, the difference is often shown by time words or context, not by verb form alone, so English requires more conscious control.

A practical way to choose is to ask: Is this generally true, repeated, or stable? Use present simple. Is it happening now, developing at the moment, or temporary? Use present continuous. Some stative verbs, such as know, like, need, believe, belong, and understand, usually do not take the continuous form in normal use.

Vietnamese learner alert/Lưu ý cho người Việt

- Third person singular in present simple takes -s: works, studies, tries, goes, watches.
- Present continuous needs be + verb-ing: am working, is studying, are trying.
- Do not overuse now as a substitute for the continuous form. Change the verb form too.
- Stative verbs are usually simple, not continuous: I know, I like, I need.

Core patterns

Pattern	Use	Example
subject + base/base+s	habit, routine, fact	She takes the bus every day.
subject + be + verb-ing	now or temporary action	She is taking a training course this month.
do/does + subject + base	questions in present simple	Do you live nearby?
be + subject + verb-ing	questions in present continuous	Are you working now?
usually/often/always	common present simple markers	I usually cook at home.
now/right now/at the moment/currently	common continuous markers	We are currently updating the plan.

Useful speaking examples

- I usually start work at eight, but this week I am starting earlier.
- My brother lives in Can Tho, but he is staying with us for a few days.
- I don't usually drink coffee at night.
- Are you using this chair, or can I take it?

Useful writing examples

- The graph shows how energy use changes across the year.
- Many people prefer online shopping because it saves time.
- The company is expanding into several regional markets at present.
- Students often struggle at first, but they improve with regular practice.

Common mistakes and better English

Common mistake	Better English	Why
She go to work by bus every day.	She goes to work by bus every day.	Third person singular needs -s.
I am knowing the answer.	I know the answer.	Know is usually not used in the continuous form.
Now I study online this month.	I am studying online this month.	Temporary current situation needs the continuous form.
Do you working now?	Are you working now?	Use be + verb-ing in the present continuous question.

Mini drill

36. Choose the best form: He works/is working in a bank, but he is taking/takes a coding course this month.
37. Complete: My father usually ____ (get) up at five.
38. Complete: We ____ (prepare) for the meeting right now.
39. Correct the sentence: She is liking this song.
40. Make a question: you/live/with your parents now

Possible answers

1. He works in a bank, but he is taking a coding course this month.
2. gets
3. are preparing
4. She likes this song.
5. Are you living with your parents now?/Are you living with your parents at the moment?

Upgrade tip

• Many speaking answers become more natural when you contrast the two forms: I usually work from the office, but I am working from home today.

9. Past simple, past continuous, and used to

Practical goal: *Talk about finished past actions, background situations, and old habits with clear time meaning.*

The past simple is the normal tense for finished past actions and states: yesterday, last week, in 2022, when I was a child. The past continuous shows an action in progress at a point in the past, often as background to another action. Used to describes repeated past habits or past states that are no longer true. Vietnamese often marks past meaning with words such as đã, hồi đó, ngày trước, or context, so English learners need extra attention to verb form and time markers.

These forms are practical because daily speaking depends on them: telling stories, talking about your childhood, explaining what happened in a meeting, or describing a past trip. Good control also improves written narratives and process descriptions.

Vietnamese learner alert/Lưu ý cho người Việt

- Regular past simple usually ends in -ed, but pronunciation differs: worked /t/, played /d/, wanted /ɪd/.
- Many common verbs are irregular: go/went, see/saw, make/made, buy/bought, think/thought.
- Past continuous = was/were + verb-ing.
- Used to is followed by the base verb: I used to live there, not I used to lived there.

Core patterns

Pattern	Use	Example
subject + past simple	finished action in the past	I met her yesterday.
subject + was/were + verb-ing	background action in the past	We were eating when he called.
used to + base verb	past habit or old state	I used to play outside every evening.
did + subject + base verb	past simple question	Did you enjoy the event?
subject + did not + base verb	past simple negative	They did not agree.
while/when	connect background and main event	While I was studying, my friend sent me a message.

Useful speaking examples

- I used to be very shy, but I became more confident after university.
- When I arrived, everyone was waiting for the manager.
- We visited Hue last summer and stayed there for three days.
- Did you hear the noise last night?

Useful writing examples

- The company launched the product in 2019 and expanded rapidly over the next two years.
- While the team was discussing the budget, a technical issue delayed the presentation.
- Many people used to rely on cash, but digital payments are now more common.
- The figure increased steadily until 2015 and then fell slightly.

Common mistakes and better English

Common mistake	Better English	Why
Yesterday I go to the clinic.	Yesterday I went to the clinic.	Finished past time needs the past simple form.
I used to lived in Ha Long.	I used to live in Ha Long.	Used to takes the base verb.
When I came, she cooked dinner.	When I came, she was cooking dinner.	Background action in progress often uses the past continuous.
Did you went there?	Did you go there?	After did, use the base verb.

Mini drill

41. Complete: We ____ (watch) TV when the power went out.
42. Complete: My grandmother ____ (use) to sell vegetables in the local market.
43. Correct the sentence: Last weekend I didn't went anywhere.
44. Make a question: you/meet/him/yesterday
45. Choose the best form: While I did my homework/was doing my homework, my phone rang.

Possible answers

1. were watching
2. used
3. Last weekend I didn't go anywhere.
4. Did you meet him yesterday?
5. While I was doing my homework, my phone rang.

Upgrade tip

• In storytelling, the past simple carries the main events and the past continuous paints the background. This contrast makes spoken stories sound much more natural.

10. Present perfect and past perfect

Practical goal: *Connect past actions to the present and show the order of past events accurately.*

The present perfect is one of the hardest tenses for Vietnamese learners because it mixes past time and present relevance. It often expresses experience, a recent result, change over time, or an unfinished period that continues to now. The past perfect is easier conceptually: it shows that one past event happened before another past event. Both tenses rely on have/has/had + past participle.

A useful practical rule is this: if you mention a finished past time such as yesterday, last year, or in 2018, you usually need the past simple. If the exact time is not important and the result matters now, the present perfect is often possible. For the past perfect, use it when the sequence would otherwise be unclear.

Vietnamese learner alert/Lưu ý cho người Việt

• Present perfect is common with ever, never, already, yet, just, recently, so far, over the last few years.
• Do not combine the present perfect with finished past time expressions like yesterday or last week.
• Past perfect often appears with before, after, by the time, when, and because one action happened earlier.
• Learn irregular past participles carefully: gone, seen, done, made, written, spoken, become.

Core patterns

Pattern	Use	Example
have/has + past participle	experience or present result	I have finished the draft.
have/has not + past participle	negative perfect	She has not replied yet.
have/has + subject + past participle	question	Have you ever tried this app?
had + past participle	earlier past action	They had left before I arrived.
for/since	duration and starting point	I have worked here for three years.

Pattern	Use	Example
by the time + past clause	completed before a past point	By the time we arrived, the film had started.

Useful speaking examples

- I have never spoken in front of such a large audience before.
- She has already sent the file, so you can check your email.
- By the time I got to the station, the train had left.
- We have lived in this area since 2021.

Useful writing examples

- The use of mobile banking has increased significantly over the past decade.
- Researchers have identified several factors that contribute to learner anxiety.
- By the time the policy was introduced, many local businesses had already adjusted their prices.
- So far, the programme has achieved mixed results.

Common mistakes and better English

Common mistake	Better English	Why
I have seen him yesterday.	I saw him yesterday.	Finished past time needs the past simple.
She didn't finish the report yet.	She hasn't finished the report yet.	Yet often appears with the present perfect.
When I arrived, they already left.	When I arrived, they had already left.	The leaving happened earlier.
I am here since 2022.	I have been here since 2022.	Use the present perfect for a state continuing to now.

Mini drill

46. Complete: I ____ never ____ (try) sushi before.
47. Correct the sentence: We have visited Da Lat last summer.
48. Complete: By the time the teacher came in, the students ____ (sit) down.
49. Complete: She ____ (work) here for five years.
50. Make a question with ever: you/ride/a horse

Possible answers

1. have never tried
2. We visited Da Lat last summer.
3. had sat/had already sat
4. has worked/has been working here for five years
5. Have you ever ridden a horse?

Upgrade tip

• In formal writing, the present perfect is useful for describing trends up to now: demand has risen, interest has grown, attitudes have changed.

11. Future forms: will, be going to, present continuous, and future time clauses

Practical goal: *Talk about plans, predictions, decisions, schedules, and future conditions with the right form.*

English has several future forms because future meaning is not only about time; it is also about intention, evidence, schedule, and degree of certainty. Will often expresses a decision made at the moment of speaking, a promise, an offer, or a prediction. Be going to often expresses prior intention or a prediction based on present evidence. The present continuous often expresses arranged future plans. The present simple can also express schedules and timetables. In time clauses after when, before, after, until, and as soon as, English often uses a present form to refer to the future.

Vietnamese commonly uses sẽ and context, so learners may overuse will. Natural English sounds better when you choose the form that fits the situation, not just the future time.

Vietnamese learner alert/Lưu ý cho người Việt

- Will + base verb. Going to = be + going to + base verb.
- Use the present continuous for arranged plans: I am meeting my client tomorrow afternoon.
- Use the present simple for fixed timetables: The train leaves at 6.45.
- After when/before/after/until/as soon as, use the present tense for future meaning: I'll call you when I arrive.

Core patterns

Pattern	Use	Example
will + base verb	decision, offer, prediction	I'll help you.
be going to + base verb	plan or evidence-based prediction	It is going to rain.
be + verb-ing	arranged future plan	We are meeting on Friday.
present simple	schedule/timetable	The class starts at 9 a.m.
when/as soon as + present simple	future time clause	I'll message you when I get home.
be about to + base verb	very near future	The meeting is about to start.

Useful speaking examples

- I think prices will continue to rise next year.
- I am going to apply for a scholarship after I finish this course.
- We are having dinner with my cousins this Sunday.
- I'll call you as soon as I arrive.

Useful writing examples

- The government is likely to face increasing pressure in the coming years.
- If current trends continue, demand will grow further.
- The seminar starts at 2 p.m. and ends at 4 p.m.
- The team is going to launch the beta version next month.

Common mistakes and better English

Common mistake	Better English	Why
I will visit my aunt this weekend because we planned it last month.	I am visiting/going to visit my aunt this weekend because we planned it last month.	A prior arrangement or intention sounds better with the continuous or going to.
When I will arrive, I will text you.	When I arrive, I will text you.	Use the present simple in the time clause.
Look at those clouds! It will rain.	Look at those clouds! It is going to rain.	Visible evidence often suggests going to.
The movie will start at 7.30 according to the schedule.	The movie starts at 7.30 according to the schedule.	Schedules often use the present simple.

Mini drill

51. Choose the best form: I think he will pass/is passing the exam.
52. Complete: We ___ (meet) our partners tomorrow at 10.
53. Correct the sentence: I will tell you when I will finish.
54. Complete: Look at that motorbike! It ___ (crash) if the driver doesn't slow down.
55. Write a sentence with going to about one personal plan.

Possible answers

1. will pass
2. are meeting
3. I will tell you when I finish.
4. is going to crash
5. Possible answer: I am going to review vocabulary every evening this week.

Upgrade tip

• Natural conversation often uses mixed future forms within the same answer: I am meeting my supervisor tomorrow, and after that I will decide which topic to choose.

12. Modal verbs: ability, advice, possibility, obligation, and politeness

Practical goal: *Express attitude and meaning more precisely than with basic present and past tenses alone.*

Modal verbs are powerful because they add meaning without changing the main action. They express ability, permission, obligation, advice, probability, deduction, willingness, and politeness. In everyday English, modals help you sound softer, clearer, and more natural. In writing, they help you avoid overstatement and express degrees of certainty. Vietnamese learners often know can and must, but practical English also depends on should, could, may, might, have to, need to, must not, don't have to, would, and be able to.

Many communication problems come from choosing a modal that is too strong or too weak. For example, must can sound very forceful, while should often sounds more suitable for advice. Could can be more polite than can in requests.

Vietnamese learner alert/Lưu ý cho người Việt

- Most modal verbs are followed by the base verb: can speak, should study, might change.
- Do not add to after a modal verb, except in semi-modals like have to, need to, be able to, ought to.
- Must not means prohibition; don't have to means lack of necessity. These meanings are very different.
- Would is useful for polite requests, hypothetical situations, and repeated past willingness or preference.

Core patterns

Pattern	Use	Example
can/could	ability or polite request	Could you repeat that?
should/ought to	advice or expectation	You should revise regularly.
must/have to	strong obligation	Staff must wear ID cards.
may/might/could	possibility	This might help.
would	politeness, habit, conditional	I would prefer a quieter place.
be able to	ability in wider tense patterns	She was able to solve it.

Useful speaking examples

- Could you speak a little more slowly, please?
- You should keep a small notebook for collocations.
- I might join the workshop if I finish work early.
- You don't have to answer now; you can think about it first.

Useful writing examples

- Governments should invest more in public transport infrastructure.
- This result may reflect a temporary shift in consumer behaviour.
- Students must be given clear feedback if improvement is expected.
- A more balanced policy could reduce long-term costs.

Common mistakes and better English

Common mistake	Better English	Why
You should to sleep earlier.	You should sleep earlier.	Use the base verb after a modal.
You mustn't come tomorrow if you are busy.	You don't have to come tomorrow if you are busy.	Mustn't means not allowed; don't have to means not necessary.
I can to help after lunch.	I can help after lunch.	No to after can.
May you help me?	Could you help me?/Can you help me?	May for requests can sound unnatural in many contexts.

Mini drill

56. Choose the best modal: You ___ wear a helmet on this site. (must/might)
57. Rewrite politely: Repeat that.
58. Complete: It ___ rain later, so take an umbrella.
59. Correct the sentence: We don't must leave yet.
60. Complete with advice: You ___ back up your files regularly.

Possible answers

1. must
2. Could you repeat that, please?
3. might/may
4. We don't have to leave yet.
5. should

Upgrade tip

• In speaking, modal variety makes you sound more natural: I can do that now, I could send it later, I might need more time, I would rather check first.

13. Questions, negatives, and short answers

Practical goal: *Ask clear questions, answer naturally, and control the word order that makes English interactive.*

Conversation depends on questions and negatives. Many Vietnamese learners can make statements but become less accurate when they ask a question because English changes the word order. The pattern depends on the auxiliary verb. If the main verb is be, put be before the subject. If there is another auxiliary such as can, have, or will, move that auxiliary before the subject. If there is no auxiliary, use do/does/did. Negatives also depend on auxiliaries: is not, do not, cannot, have not, did not.

Short answers matter too. Native and fluent speakers often say Yes, I do; No, I haven't; Yes, she is; No, they can't. These answers are quicker and more natural than repeating the whole sentence every time.

Vietnamese learner alert/Lưu ý cho người Việt

• Question words usually come first: what, where, when, why, who, which, how.
• Do not use two question systems at once. For example, not “Why did you are late?”
• Short answers repeat the auxiliary, not the main verb: Do you drive? — Yes, I do.
• Negative contractions are common in speech: don't, doesn't, didn't, isn't, aren't, can't, won't, haven't.

Core patterns

Pattern	Use	Example
be + subject + complement?	question with be	Are you ready?
auxiliary + subject + base/past participle?	question with another auxiliary	Have you finished?

Pattern	Use	Example
do/does/did + subject + base verb?	question with ordinary verbs	Did she call you?
subject + auxiliary not + verb	negative sentence	I do not agree.
Yes, subject + auxiliary/No, subject + auxiliary not	short answer	Yes, they are.
question word + auxiliary + subject + verb	information question	Why did he leave?

Useful speaking examples

- Do you usually work better in the morning or at night?
- Why don't we review the plan once more before the meeting?
- Have you ever had to make an important decision very quickly?
- No, I don't, but I would like to learn.

Useful writing examples

- This raises an important question: how can access be improved fairly?
- The data do not explain why this change occurred.
- It is not clear whether the policy will be effective in smaller cities.
- Why are so many young people choosing flexible work instead of stable office jobs?

Common mistakes and better English

Common mistake	Better English	Why
Where you live?	Where do you live?	Use do for an ordinary present simple question.
Why did you were late?	Why were you late?	Use one question system, not two.
No, I don't have.	No, I don't.	Short answers repeat the auxiliary only.
He don't like crowded places.	He doesn't like crowded places.	Third person singular uses doesn't.

Mini drill

61. Make a question: she/enjoy/the event
62. Make a question: where/you/go/last night
63. Give a short answer: Can you swim? — no
64. Correct the sentence: Why you didn't reply to me?
65. Make a negative sentence: they/understand/the instructions

Possible answers

1. Does she enjoy the event?
2. Where did you go last night?
3. No, I can't.

4. Why didn't you reply to me?
5. They do not understand the instructions.

Upgrade tip

• In real conversation, question grammar and intonation work together. Even a correct question sounds stronger when the stress falls on the key word: Where did you GO?

14. Gerunds and infinitives

Practical goal: *Choose between verb + -ing, verb + to infinitive, and other common verb patterns.*

English verbs do not all connect to the next verb in the same way. After some verbs, you use a gerund (-ing form). After others, you use a to-infinitive. Some verbs can take both but with the same or different meanings. Vietnamese does not mark this connection in the same way, so learners often make mistakes such as “I enjoy to read” or “He decided going abroad.” These errors sound obvious to advanced listeners and reduce writing accuracy.

Instead of trying to find a deep logic for every verb, learn the most useful patterns in groups. Verbs of enjoyment and avoidance often take -ing. Verbs of decision, hope, plan, and need often take the to-infinitive. Some verbs take object + to-infinitive, such as tell, ask, encourage, and want.

Vietnamese learner alert/Lưu ý cho người Việt

• Common -ing verbs: enjoy, avoid, consider, suggest, keep, finish, mind, practise.
• Common to-infinitive verbs: decide, hope, plan, want, need, learn, promise, try, agree.
• Common object + to-infinitive verbs: ask someone to do, tell someone to do, encourage someone to do, want someone to do.
• After prepositions, use -ing: interested in learning, good at speaking, before leaving.

Core patterns

Pattern	Use	Example
verb + V-ing	activity as noun/after certain verbs	I enjoy reading.
verb + to-infinitive	plan, intention, decision, need	She decided to wait.
verb + object + to-infinitive	direct someone to act	The teacher told us to revise.
be + adjective + to-infinitive	purpose or evaluation	It is important to listen.
preposition + V-ing	verb after a preposition	Thank you for helping.
stop/remember/forget/try	special meaning changes	I remembered to lock the door.

Useful speaking examples

- I enjoy learning through short videos, but I still need to practise writing.
- My manager asked me to send the final version before noon.
- I am interested in working with people from different cultures.
- We decided to leave early to avoid the traffic.

Useful writing examples

- Students need to develop the habit of checking their grammar carefully.
- One effective way to improve speaking is to record yourself regularly.
- The policy encourages companies to invest in cleaner technology.
- Many people avoid using public transport because they expect delays.

Common mistakes and better English

Common mistake	Better English	Why
I enjoy to read in the evening.	I enjoy reading in the evening.	Enjoy is followed by -ing.
She decided going abroad.	She decided to go abroad.	Decide is followed by the to-infinitive.
Thank you to help me.	Thank you for helping me.	After the preposition for, use -ing.
My parents let me to choose my major.	My parents let me choose my major.	Let is followed by object + base verb, not to-infinitive.

Mini drill

66. Complete: I hope ___ (improve) my pronunciation.
67. Complete: He suggested ___ (take) a short break.
68. Correct the sentence: She is good at to explain difficult ideas.
69. Complete: The coach encouraged us ___ (keep) going.
70. Choose the best form: I remembered locking/to lock the door before I left.

Possible answers

1. to improve
2. taking
3. She is good at explaining difficult ideas.
4. to keep
5. to lock

Upgrade tip

• When you learn a new verb, never write only the verb. Write its pattern too: suggest doing, decide to do, prevent someone from doing, allow someone to do.

15. Passive voice and impersonal structures

Practical goal: *Focus on results, processes, and actions when the doer is unknown, unimportant, or obvious.*

The passive voice is common in formal writing, reports, processes, and academic language because it shifts focus from the actor to the action or result. It is made with be + past participle. Many Vietnamese learners either avoid the passive completely or overuse it. The key is to use it when the receiver of the action is more important than the doer, or when the doer is unknown or unnecessary.

English also uses impersonal structures such as it is believed that, it is often argued that, people say that, and there is/are. These structures are practical for writing because they help you sound neutral and analytical. In speaking, passives can be useful too: I was told to wait, My order was cancelled, The road is being repaired.

Vietnamese learner alert/Lưu ý cho người Việt

• Passive = be + past participle, and the be form changes with tense: is made, was built, has been improved, will be discussed.
• Use by + agent only when the doer is important: The novel was written by Toni Morrison.
• Do not force the passive if the active voice is shorter and clearer.
• Many academic-style sentences can be improved with impersonal frames such as It is widely believed that ...

Core patterns

Pattern	Use	Example
be + past participle	basic passive	The report was completed.
be being/been + past participle	continuous/perfect passive	The bridge is being repaired.
modal + be + past participle	modal passive	The issue should be discussed.
it is said/believed/argued that ...	impersonal reporting	It is widely believed that sleep affects learning.
there is/are	existence	There are several causes.
have/get something done	arranged service	I had my phone repaired.

Useful speaking examples

- My package was delivered to the wrong address.
- The road is being repaired, so traffic is slower than usual.
- I had my laptop cleaned last week.
- We were told to wait outside for a few minutes.

Useful writing examples

- A number of practical measures should be introduced immediately.
- The data were collected over a six-month period.
- It is often argued that technology reduces face-to-face interaction.
- The final decision will be made after further consultation.

Common mistakes and better English

Common mistake	Better English	Why
The report finished yesterday.	The report was finished yesterday./They finished the report yesterday.	Choose active or passive clearly.
The road repairing now.	The road is being repaired now.	Need be + being + past participle.
People believe this method is useful, and it is believed this method useful.	People believe this method is useful, and it is believed that this method is useful.	Impersonal pattern needs that-clause.
I made my hair cut yesterday.	I had my hair cut yesterday.	Use have/get something done for services.

Mini drill

71. Change to passive: They announced the results this morning.
72. Complete: The proposal should ____ (review) carefully.
73. Correct the sentence: My phone stolen on the bus yesterday.
74. Write an impersonal sentence with believe about reading habits.
75. Complete: The building ____ (construct) in 2010.

Possible answers

1. The results were announced this morning.
2. be reviewed
3. My phone was stolen on the bus yesterday.
4. Possible answer: It is widely believed that regular reading improves concentration.
5. was constructed

Upgrade tip

• In strong writing, mix active and passive voices strategically. Use active voice for clarity and passive voice when you want to highlight process, policy, or outcome.

16. Conditionals, relative clauses, and longer sentences

Practical goal: *Express real and unreal conditions, add detail efficiently, and combine ideas into mature sentences.*

Longer English sentences are not simply a matter of adding more words. They require clear logical relationships between clauses. Conditionals help you express real possibilities, imagined situations, consequences, warnings, and recommendations. Relative clauses help you add information about a noun without starting a completely new sentence. These structures are essential for formal writing and for sophisticated speaking.

Vietnamese learners sometimes avoid these structures because shorter sentences feel safer. However, high-quality English depends on controlled complexity, not only simple accuracy. The goal is not to create very long sentences, but to create clean sentences in which every part has a purpose and the reader can still follow easily.

Vietnamese learner alert/Lưu ý cho người Việt

• First conditional: If + present simple, will + base verb. Real future possibility.
• Second conditional: If + past simple, would + base verb. Imagined or less real situation now/future.
• Third conditional: If + had + past participle, would have + past participle. Imagined past result.
• Relative clauses use who, whom, whose, which, that, where, when. In defining clauses, that is common and commas are not used.

Core patterns

Pattern	Use	Example
If + present, will + base	real future conditional	If you revise daily, you will improve.
If + past, would + base	hypothetical present/future	If I had more time, I would travel more.
If + had + pp, would have + pp	hypothetical past	If I had known, I would have called.

Pattern	Use	Example
noun + who/which/that + clause	relative clause	The book that you recommended was excellent.
non-defining relative clause	extra information with commas	My brother, who lives in Hue, is visiting us.
because/although/while/whereas/so that	logical clause links	Although it was expensive, we bought it.

Useful speaking examples

- If I had more free time, I would join a speaking club.
- People who work long hours often find it hard to maintain healthy habits.
- If the traffic is too heavy, I'll take the metro instead.
- Although I was nervous at first, the presentation went better than I expected.

Useful writing examples

- If governments invest in public transport, congestion will probably decrease over time.
- Students who receive regular feedback tend to make faster progress.
- The company introduced a flexible policy, which helped many parents return to work.
- If the issue had been addressed earlier, the cost might have been lower.

Common mistakes and better English

Common mistake	Better English	Why
If I will have time, I will join.	If I have time, I will join.	Use the present simple in the if-clause.
The people which work here are friendly.	The people who work here are friendly.	Use who for people.
My hometown, that is near the sea, attracts many tourists.	My hometown, which is near the sea, attracts many tourists.	That is not usually used in non-defining relative clauses.
If I knew about the event yesterday, I would join.	If I had known about the event yesterday, I would have joined.	Past unreal meaning needs the third conditional.

Mini drill

76. Complete: If you ____ (want) better results, you need a better routine.
77. Complete: I would buy that course if it ____ (be) cheaper.
78. Join the sentences with a relative clause: I met a woman. She runs a language centre.
79. Correct the sentence: If he studied harder, he will pass.
80. Join the ideas with although: The hotel was expensive. We stayed there.

Possible answers

1. want
2. were
3. I met a woman who runs a language centre.
4. If he studied harder, he would pass.
5. Although the hotel was expensive, we stayed there.

Upgrade tip

• A mature paragraph usually mixes simple, compound, and complex sentences. Use complexity to clarify relationships, not to impress with length.

17. Reported speech and reporting verbs

Practical goal: *Report what people said in a natural way for conversation, summaries, and formal writing.*

Reported speech allows you to tell someone what another person said without quoting their exact words. This skill is common in daily conversation, meetings, news summaries, and academic-style writing. In informal speech, you can often use simple patterns such as He said he was tired or She told me to wait. In more formal writing, reporting verbs such as argue, claim, suggest, explain, admit, recommend, and emphasise help you summarise ideas accurately.

Vietnamese learners sometimes avoid reported speech because of tense changes, pronoun changes, and time-word changes. The practical goal is not to memorise every possible shift at once; it is to handle the most useful patterns confidently.

Vietnamese learner alert/Lưu ý cho người Việt

• Common patterns: say that..., tell someone that..., tell someone to..., ask whether/if..., ask someone to...
• Backshifting often happens when the reporting verb is in the past: 'I am tired' → He said he was tired.
• Time and place words may change: today → that day, tomorrow → the next day, here → there, now → then.
• In writing, reporting verbs help you express stance: argue, suggest, note, point out, emphasise.

Core patterns

Pattern	Use	Example
say that + clause	report information	She said that she was busy.
tell + person + clause	tell someone information	He told me that the class was cancelled.
tell/ask + person + to-infinitive	commands and requests	The manager asked us to wait.
ask if/whether + clause	yes/no reported question	She asked whether I was free.
ask + question word + clause	reported information question	He asked where I lived.
reporting verb + that-clause	formal source summary	Researchers argue that sleep affects memory.

Useful speaking examples

- My friend told me that the traffic was terrible, so I left earlier.
- She asked me to send the link after dinner.
- He said he would call back later.
- The receptionist asked whether I had an appointment.

Useful writing examples

- Several experts argue that digital tools should support, rather than replace, human teachers.
- The report notes that rural households face greater transport costs.

- Participants explained that lack of time was their main obstacle.
- The author suggests that frequent review is more effective than last-minute memorisation.

Common mistakes and better English

Common mistake	Better English	Why
She said me that she was busy.	She told me that she was busy./She said that she was busy.	Use tell + person, or say without a direct object.
He asked me where do I live.	He asked me where I lived.	Reported questions use statement word order.
My teacher suggested me to read more.	My teacher suggested reading more./My teacher told me to read more.	Suggest does not normally take object + to-infinitive.
She told that the office was closed.	She said that the office was closed./She told us that the office was closed.	Tell usually needs an object.

Mini drill

81. Report this sentence: 'I can't come tonight,' Lan said.
82. Report this request: 'Please sit down,' the teacher said to us.
83. Correct the sentence: He asked me what time did the train leave.
84. Write one sentence with argue that about education.
85. Change to reported speech: 'We will finish it tomorrow,' they said.

Possible answers

1. Lan said that she couldn't come that night.
2. The teacher told us to sit down.
3. He asked me what time the train left.
4. Possible answer: Many teachers argue that homework should be purposeful, not excessive.
5. They said that they would finish it the next day.

Upgrade tip

• In higher-level writing, reporting verbs are better than repeating say. Compare: The writer says... vs The writer argues, claims, notes, concedes, challenges, or recommends...

PART III

Practical writing

Move from grammar knowledge to real writing: sentences, paragraphs, linking, register, editing, and higher-range style.

18. Writing clear sentences: subject, verb, control

Good writing does not start with long vocabulary lists; it starts with sentence control. A clear sentence has a stable structure, one main idea, and a reader-friendly order. Many Vietnamese learners know enough vocabulary to express an idea, but their writing still feels weak because the sentence frame is unstable. The most common problems are missing subjects, weak verb choices, too many ideas in one sentence, and direct translation from Vietnamese order.

When you write, first choose the core message. Then build it with a strong verb. After that, add detail in the order that makes the sentence easy to read. If a sentence becomes too long, cut it into two sentences or turn one part into a phrase.

Key principles

- Make the main idea visible early. Do not hide the subject and verb inside a long phrase.
- Prefer a clear verb to a weak structure with many nouns. Compare: The city experienced rapid growth, not The city had a rapid growth.
- Use one sentence for one main step of thought. If you add too many because/which/and parts, the sentence becomes hard to control.
- Read the sentence aloud. If you need extra breaths, the sentence may need to be divided or simplified.
- After you draft a paragraph, highlight every be verb. Some are necessary, but too many may mean your writing needs stronger verbs.

Useful frames

Function	Frame
Main statement	The main reason is that ...
Cause and effect	... because .../This leads to .../As a result, ...
Contrast	However, .../In contrast, .../Although ..., ...
Example	For example, .../A clear example of this is ...
Result + explanation	This change can be explained by ...
Evaluation	This approach is effective because ...

Common writing problems

Problem	Better choice
There are many people choose online courses because convenient.	Many people choose online courses because they are convenient.
The reason is because students are busy.	The reason is that students are busy.
This trend has a bad influence for young people.	This trend has a bad influence on young people.
Nowadays people they can study anywhere.	Nowadays people can study anywhere.

Practice tasks

86. Rewrite with a stronger verb: There is a rapid increase in online shopping.
87. Rewrite more clearly: Because the bus was late and I was tired and the weather was bad, so I arrived in a bad mood.
88. Write one sentence about your study habit using because.
89. Write one sentence about your city using however.

Possible lines/model sentences

- Online shopping increased rapidly.
- Because the bus was late and the weather was bad, I arrived tired and in a bad mood.
- Possible answer: I review vocabulary every morning because my mind is clearer at that time.
- Possible answer: My city is crowded during rush hour; however, it becomes much quieter after 9 p.m.

Quick checklist

• Can I identify the subject and verb immediately?
• Does the sentence have one main focus?
• Did I avoid direct translation from Vietnamese word order?
• Can I replace a weak phrase with a stronger verb?

19. Building paragraphs that actually develop an idea

A paragraph is not just a group of sentences on the same topic. A strong paragraph has a focus, a plan, and a clear movement from point to support. In practical English writing, a simple paragraph often has four parts: topic sentence, explanation, example, and mini-conclusion or link forward. Vietnamese learners often write paragraphs that circle around one topic without a clear line of development. This makes the writing feel repetitive or unfocused.

If you can build strong paragraphs, essays, reports, emails, and exam answers all become easier. Instead of thinking about a full page, think about one useful paragraph at a time.

Key principles

- Start with a clear topic sentence. The reader should know the paragraph's main point immediately.
- Use the middle of the paragraph to explain the point, not to change the topic.
- Include evidence, an example, or a specific detail. General statements alone feel weak.
- End with a sentence that shows the result, significance, or transition to the next idea.
- Keep unity: if a sentence does not support the topic sentence, move it or delete it.

Useful frames

Function	Frame
Topic sentence	One major reason for this trend is that ...
Explanation	This is mainly because ...
Example	For instance, ...
Result	As a result, ...
Mini-conclusion	Therefore, it is clear that ...
Transition	This point also connects to ...

Common writing problems

Problem	Better choice
Paragraph starts with example only	Start with the main point first, then give the example.
Different ideas mixed together	Put one main controlling idea in each paragraph.
Repeating the same point with different words	Add explanation, evidence, or consequence instead of repetition.
Very short paragraph with one sentence only	Develop the point with at least one explanation and one example when possible.

Practice tasks

90. Write a topic sentence about why public transport matters.
91. Add one explanation and one example.
92. Write a four-sentence paragraph about the value of reading in English.
93. Write a paragraph about working from home using one contrast sentence.

Possible lines/model sentences

- One major reason public transport matters is that it reduces the pressure on crowded roads.
- This is especially important in large cities where thousands of people commute at the same time.
- For example, a reliable metro system can move large numbers of passengers faster than private cars during rush hour.
- As a result, better public transport can save time, reduce stress, and lower pollution.

Quick checklist

- Does the first sentence clearly state the point?
- Did I explain the point instead of repeating it?
- Did I include an example or specific support?
- Does the paragraph end in a meaningful way?

20. Linking ideas naturally, not mechanically

Linking words are useful, but many learners overuse them or use them in the wrong place. Good writing is coherent because the logic is clear, not because every sentence begins with moreover or besides. Some relationships can be shown through grammar, pronouns, repetition of key words, or cause-and-effect verbs. Linkers should support the flow, not carry the whole paragraph alone.

For Vietnamese learners, the practical challenge is balance. Use a range of connectors, but choose them by function: addition, contrast, cause, result, example, concession, or summary. Learn the punctuation patterns too, because punctuation controls how linkers work in writing.

Key principles

- Choose the linker that matches the logic exactly: however for contrast, therefore for result, for example for illustration, although for concession.
- Do not use too many sentence-initial linkers. Sometimes a simple pronoun or a repeated key noun is enough.
- Remember punctuation: However, .../..., whereas .../Although ..., .../... because ...
- Use clause linkers and sentence adverbs, not only one type. Mix because, although, while, which means, therefore, as a result, in contrast.

Useful frames

Function	Frame
Addition	also, in addition, moreover, another point is that ...
Contrast	however, in contrast, whereas, although ...
Cause	because, since, due to, as a result of ...
Result	therefore, so, consequently, as a result ...
Example	for example, for instance, such as ...
Summary	overall, in short, in summary ...

Common writing problems

Problem	Better choice
Although ... but ...	Use although or but, not both together in the same clause pattern.
Because ... so ...	Use because or so, depending on the structure.
On the other hand used without a first hand	Use on the other hand only when you are clearly balancing another point.
Besides overused for formal addition	In formal writing, in addition or moreover is often safer.

Practice tasks

94. Join the ideas with although: The task was difficult. We completed it on time.
95. Join the ideas with therefore: Public transport is unreliable. Many people prefer motorbikes.
96. Write one sentence using whereas.
97. Write one sentence using for example.

Possible lines/model sentences

- Although the task was difficult, we completed it on time.
- Public transport is unreliable; therefore, many people prefer motorbikes.
- Possible answer: Rural areas face different transport problems, whereas large cities struggle more with congestion.
- Possible answer: Many small habits can improve speaking; for example, recording yourself for two minutes a day builds confidence.

Quick checklist

• Did I choose the linker for the correct function?
• Did I avoid because...so and although...but?
• Did I vary my linking methods?
• Does the punctuation match the linker?

21. Formal and informal English: choosing the right register

English changes according to situation. The language you use in a message to a friend is not the same as the language you use in a report, scholarship application, or email to a lecturer. Vietnamese learners often produce writing that is grammatically correct but too conversational, or speaking that is too formal and distant. Register control means matching your language to the relationship, purpose, and setting.

Formal English is usually more explicit, more precise, and less emotional. Informal English is shorter, more direct, and more flexible. Good learners can move between the two styles when needed.

Key principles

- In formal writing, avoid slang, very personal fillers, and vague words like stuff, things, nice, bad when a more precise word exists.
- In informal messages, shorter sentences and contractions are normal: I'm, don't, can't, thanks, see you soon.
- Formal requests often use would, could, I would appreciate, I am writing to, I would be grateful if ...
- Choose verbs carefully: buy/purchase, get/receive, help/assist, start/commence. Do not force formal words where simple words are clearer.

Useful frames

Function	Frame
Formal request	I am writing to ask whether ...
Formal appreciation	I would appreciate your advice on ...
Neutral opinion	In my view, ...
Informal opener	Hi ..., just a quick message about ...
Polite softener	Could you please ... ?

Function	Frame
Formal closing	Thank you for your time and consideration.

Common writing problems

Problem	Better choice
Hey teacher, I want you check my essay.	Dear Ms Nguyen, could you please check my essay when you have time?
The government should fix many bad things.	The government should address several serious issues.
I wanna know your feedback.	I would like to know your feedback.
Respected sir, I hope this email finds you in the pink of health.	Dear Sir/Madam, I hope you are well.

Practice tasks

98. Rewrite informally: I would appreciate it if you could send the file by 5 p.m.
99. Rewrite formally: Hey, can you tell me about the schedule?
100. Write one formal email opening.
101. Write one informal message to postpone a meeting with a friend.

Possible lines/model sentences

- Can you send the file by 5 p.m., please?
- Could you tell me about the schedule, please?
- Possible answer: I am writing to ask for information about the next training session.
- Possible answer: Hi Minh, something urgent has come up. Can we move our meeting to tomorrow evening?

Quick checklist

• Who am I writing to?
• What tone fits this relationship?
• Is my vocabulary too casual or too stiff?
• Did I use a natural opening and closing?

22. Practical writing types: messages, emails, opinions, explanations, and descriptions

Most learners need useful writing long before they need academic essays. They need messages, replies, explanations, short opinions, introductions, requests, complaints, and descriptions. The practical secret is to master a few repeatable structures that can be adapted quickly. Once the structure is stable, you can focus on grammar accuracy and vocabulary choice.

This chapter gives model frames for common written tasks. You do not need to memorise every sentence exactly; instead, learn the move sequence: open, give context, state the main point, add detail, close politely or clearly.

Key principles

- Messages should be direct and clear. The reader should understand the action quickly.
- Emails need a purpose line, necessary detail, and a suitable ending.
- Opinion paragraphs need a position, a reason, and support.
- Explanations need sequence and cause-effect language.
- Descriptions need organisation: overall impression first, then details.

Useful frames

Function	Frame
Short message	Hi ..., I'm writing to let you know that ...
Polite email	Dear ..., I am writing regarding ...
Opinion	I believe that ... mainly because ...
Explanation	This happens because ... As a result, ...
Description	Overall, ... In detail, ...
Complaint/request	I am writing to report ... and to request ...

Common writing problems

Problem	Better choice
No subject line and no context in email	State the purpose early: I am writing regarding the schedule change.
Too many details before the main point	Put the request or key message near the beginning.
Opinion without support	Give at least one reason and one example.
Description without overall view	Start with an overview before small details.

Practice tasks

102. Write a short email asking a teacher for an appointment.
103. Write a message to a classmate explaining why you will be late.
104. Write a five-sentence opinion paragraph about learning online.
105. Write a short description of your neighbourhood.

Possible lines/model sentences

- Possible email opening: Dear Ms Hoa, I am writing to ask whether I could meet you briefly after class on Thursday.
- Possible message: Hi Nam, the bus is delayed because of heavy rain, so I'll be about fifteen minutes late.
- Possible opinion line: I believe online learning is valuable because it gives students greater flexibility and access to more resources.
- Possible description: Overall, my neighbourhood is busy but convenient, with small cafés, local shops, and a park within walking distance.

Quick checklist

- Did I state my purpose early?
- Did I include only relevant details?
- Is the tone suitable?
- Did I end clearly?

23. Editing for grammar, vocabulary, and punctuation

Strong writers do not only write; they revise. Editing is where grammar knowledge becomes practical skill. Many Vietnamese learners read their own writing only for meaning: they know what they wanted to say, so they miss small errors. Good editing means reading with a checklist and looking at one layer at a time. First check sentence structure. Then check verb forms. Then noun forms and articles. Then prepositions, pronouns, word choice, spelling, and punctuation.

Do not try to fix everything at once. Use passes. Each pass has a single question. This method is faster and more reliable than staring at the same paragraph and hoping to notice every mistake.

Key principles

- Pass 1: subject + verb + complete sentence.
- Pass 2: tense, agreement, helper verbs, and verb patterns.
- Pass 3: articles, plural forms, countability, and pronouns.
- Pass 4: collocations, prepositions, register, and word choice.
- Pass 5: punctuation, capitals, spacing, and spelling.

Useful frames

Function	Frame
Check question	Does every sentence have a clear subject and a correct verb?
Verb check	Is the tense consistent with the time meaning?
Noun check	Do singular countable nouns have articles or determiners?
Word choice check	Is this the natural collocation?
Punctuation check	Do I need a comma after this linker?
Final read	Would I say this sentence to a real person?

Common writing problems

Problem	Better choice
Many small errors left after first draft	Use a systematic editing order.
Correct grammar but unnatural collocation	Check word partnerships, not only grammar.
One long sentence with several hidden errors	Split the sentence first, then edit each part.

Problem	Better choice
No final read aloud	Reading aloud reveals rhythm, missing words, and awkward repetition.

Practice tasks

106. Edit this: Students should to learn how managing money because it are important.
107. Edit this: In my opinion the online classes is useful however students need more interaction.
108. Write your personal five-step editing routine.
109. Choose one old paragraph and mark article errors in a different colour.

Possible lines/model sentences

- Students should learn how to manage money because it is important.
- In my opinion, online classes are useful; however, students need more interaction.
- Possible routine: sentence frame -> verb form -> noun/article -> collocation/preposition -> punctuation/read aloud.
- Possible observation: I often forget a/an before singular countable nouns.

Quick checklist

- Did I edit in passes?
- Did I read aloud at least once?
- Did I check collocations, not just grammar rules?
- Did I remove repetition and unnecessary words?

24. Common written error patterns for Vietnamese learners

Some mistakes appear again and again because they come from differences between Vietnamese and English. If you know the pattern, you can catch the mistake more quickly. This chapter does not teach new grammar; it teaches awareness. Many learners plateau because they keep making the same ten or twenty errors. A practical writer studies personal error patterns and attacks them directly.

The most efficient approach is to keep a small table with three columns: my mistake, the correct pattern, and one new example from my life. The error must become visible before it can disappear.

Key principles

- Notice repeated missing be, article errors, and plural -s errors.
- Watch for direct translation of Vietnamese expressions such as open the light, learn knowledge, discuss about, very delicious, or until now I still ...
- Check sentence openings: many errors happen when you begin with because, although, if, or when.
- Track weak vocabulary habits such as overusing very, good, bad, big, small, nice, and thing.

Useful frames

Function	Frame
Error log line	Wrong: .../Correct: .../New example: ...
Contrast line	In Vietnamese I often say ...; in English I should say ...
Reminder line	After enjoy, use V-ing.

Function	Frame
Article reminder	Singular countable noun? Add a/an/the/my/this/one.
Collocation reminder	Do homework, make a decision, take a photo, have a problem.
Clarity reminder	One paragraph = one main point.

Common writing problems

Problem	Better choice
I very like this idea.	I really like this idea.
She has many works to do.	She has a lot of work to do.
According to me, this rule is unfair.	In my view, this rule is unfair.
The people is friendly.	The people are friendly.
It helps me have more knowledges.	It helps me gain more knowledge.
I am living here since 2020.	I have lived here since 2020.

Practice tasks

110. Choose three mistakes from this chapter that you often make.
111. Write one correct sentence for each.
112. Create a one-page personal error log for this week.
113. Underline every article in one of your own paragraphs.

Possible lines/model sentences

- Possible answer: I really like listening to podcasts on the bus.
- Possible answer: My internship gave me practical knowledge about customer service.
- Possible answer: In my view, students need more career guidance before graduation.
- Possible answer: I have lived in this neighbourhood since 2020.

Quick checklist

• Do I know my top five repeated errors?
• Have I written a corrected example for each one?
• Can I explain why each error happens?
• Am I checking for these errors during editing?

25. Writing upgrade toolkit: sentence variety and lexical range

Once your grammar is stable, the next step is range. Strong writing uses different sentence shapes, precise verbs, useful nominal groups, and controlled emphasis. Range does not mean using difficult words everywhere. It means choosing the best structure for the job. Sometimes a short sentence has the strongest impact. Sometimes a complex sentence shows a clear relationship. Sometimes a noun phrase is more concise than a whole clause.

For Vietnamese learners, the safe path to better writing is not decorative vocabulary. It is controlled variety: a mix of simple, compound, and complex sentences; a mix of active and passive; and a vocabulary bank built around collocations and topic-specific precision.

Key principles

- Vary sentence openings: adverbial phrase, subject, subordinate clause, participle phrase, question, contrast marker.
- Use stronger verbs: increase, reduce, encourage, limit, improve, prevent, strengthen, weaken, highlight, reveal.
- Use noun phrases to compress meaning: urban transport problems, long-term financial pressure, effective language-learning habits.
- Avoid repetition by using pronouns, synonyms, reference words, and restructuring.
- Control emphasis: It is X that ..., What matters most is ..., One key point is that ...

Useful frames

Function	Frame
Strong verb pattern	The policy reduced costs but improved access.
Noun phrase pattern	long-term environmental damage
Contrast pattern	While this option is cheaper, it is less reliable.
Emphasis pattern	What matters most is consistent daily practice.
Concession pattern	Although the idea is attractive, it may not be practical.
Result pattern	This shift has led to greater flexibility.

Common writing problems

Problem	Better choice
Very + basic adjective repeated many times	Use more precise adjectives or verbs.
Same sentence opening in every line	Vary the structure while keeping clarity.
Forced advanced word that sounds unnatural	Use precise but natural vocabulary.
Long sentence with no clear main verb	Keep the grammatical spine visible.

Practice tasks

114. Rewrite with a stronger verb: This policy can make traffic less bad.
115. Rewrite with a noun phrase: the pressure that is related to money in the long term
116. Write one sentence with while to compare two options.
117. Write one sentence with What matters most is ...

Possible lines/model sentences

- This policy can reduce traffic congestion.
- long-term financial pressure
- Possible answer: While online classes are flexible, face-to-face lessons often provide faster feedback.
- Possible answer: What matters most is building a study routine that you can actually maintain.

Quick checklist

• Did I vary sentence shape without losing clarity?
• Did I choose precise verbs and collocations?
• Did I avoid repetition?
• Does the paragraph sound controlled rather than translated?

PART IV

Practical speaking

Build usable spoken English for daily life, class, work, meetings, and clear self-expression.

26. Everyday conversation grammar

Practical speaking starts with patterns you can use every day. Many learners wait until their grammar is perfect before they try to speak freely. This slows progress. Instead, build a small set of reliable structures for introductions, daily routines, likes and dislikes, plans, problems, and simple opinions. When these frames become automatic, your attention is free for vocabulary, pronunciation, and interaction.

Everyday conversation also rewards short, clear sentences more than long, complicated ones. Accuracy matters, but response speed matters too. Train chunks that are grammatically stable and easy to expand.

Speaking principles

- Start with frames you can personalise: I usually..., I'm working on..., I tend to..., What I enjoy most is ...
- Use follow-up sentences to extend your answer: because..., so..., especially..., but..., which means ...
- Do not try to sound advanced too early. Natural, accurate basic English is far more useful than risky complex sentences.
- Recycling grammar in conversation builds fluency faster than silent study alone.

High-value chunks

Function	Natural English
Introducing yourself	I'm from ..., but I'm living in ... at the moment.
Routine	I usually ..., but on weekends I ...
Preference	I really like ..., especially when ...
Problem	The main problem is that ...
Plan	I'm planning to ... next month.
Simple opinion	I think ... because ...

Common speaking mistakes

Common mistake	Better English
My name Minh.	My name is Minh.
I very like coffee.	I really like coffee.
I am work in marketing.	I work in marketing./I am working in marketing this year.
I have 25 years old.	I am 25 years old.

Practice tasks

118. Introduce yourself in four sentences.
119. Describe your weekday routine in five sentences.
120. Explain one thing you enjoy and one thing you find difficult in English.
121. Give a short opinion about online learning.

Micro-drills

- Extend this answer: I work in an office. -> add place, routine, and feeling.
- Extend this answer: I like reading. -> add why and when.
- Change to a negative answer: I usually go out on Friday night.

Model lines

- I'm from Quang Nam, but I'm living in Da Nang at the moment.
- I usually wake up at six, make coffee, and review a few words before work.
- I really enjoy listening practice because I can study while commuting.
- I think online learning is useful because it gives people more flexibility.

27. Asking and answering questions naturally

Fluent conversation depends not only on answering questions, but also on asking them back. Vietnamese learners sometimes answer politely but do not extend the interaction, so the conversation ends quickly. Natural speakers often answer, add one detail, and then ask a related question. This pattern is powerful for interviews, networking, class discussion, and everyday social interaction.

Good question handling also requires flexible grammar. You need yes/no questions, wh-questions, indirect questions, and softening phrases that make a question sound polite rather than aggressive.

Speaking principles

- Answer first, then expand, then return the question when appropriate.
- Use indirect questions to sound more polite: Could I ask what you mean by ... ?
- When you do not understand, ask for repetition or clarification immediately.
- Keep a bank of follow-up questions for common topics: work, study, hobbies, travel, food, goals.

High-value chunks

Function	Natural English
Clarifying	Sorry, could you say that again?
Checking meaning	Do you mean ... ?
Returning question	How about you?
Indirect question	Could you tell me how this works?
Follow-up	What made you choose that?
Time-gaining	That's a good question. Let me think for a second.

Common speaking mistakes

Common mistake	Better English
How about your opinion?	What do you think?/How about you?
Can you explain me this word?	Can you explain this word to me?
What means this?	What does this mean?
Where you bought it?	Where did you buy it?

Practice tasks

122. Answer this question in three parts: Why are you learning English?
123. Ask one follow-up question after hearing: I'm studying accounting.
124. Request clarification politely when you miss a word.
125. Turn a direct question into a softer indirect question.

Micro-drills

- Convert to indirect question: When does the class end?
- Write three polite clarification phrases.
- Write three follow-up questions about hobbies.

Model lines

- I'm learning English because I need it for work, and I also want to travel more confidently. How about you?
- What made you choose accounting?
- Sorry, I didn't catch the last word. Could you repeat it, please?
- Could you tell me when the next session starts?

28. Giving opinions, agreeing, disagreeing, and softening your voice

Many learners know how to say I agree and I disagree, but real conversation needs more range. In English, especially in professional or academic contexts, direct disagreement can sound too sharp if it is not softened. Practical speaking requires not only grammar accuracy but also interpersonal control. You need ways to sound confident without sounding rude.

This chapter focuses on chunks that help you express opinions with different strengths. Some phrases sound strong and certain; others sound careful and open. This control is useful in meetings, seminars, class discussions, and exam-style speaking.

Speaking principles

- Use graded opinion language: I think, I believe, it seems to me, I'm not entirely convinced that ..., I strongly believe ...
- Agree first, then add nuance when necessary: I see your point, but ...
- Use softeners for polite disagreement: I'm not sure I completely agree, Another way to look at it is ...
- Give a reason after your opinion. Unsupported opinions sound weak.

High-value chunks

Function	Natural English
Strong opinion	I strongly believe that ...
Balanced opinion	In my view, ...
Soft disagreement	I'm not sure I completely agree because ...
Partial agreement	I agree up to a point, but ...
Adding nuance	That may be true, but we also need to consider ...
Concluding view	Overall, I'd say that ...

Common speaking mistakes

Common mistake	Better English
I am totally disagree.	I totally disagree./I completely disagree.
According to me ...	In my view .../In my opinion ...
I think so because yes.	Give a reason after your opinion.
You are wrong.	I see it differently./I'm not sure I agree.

Practice tasks

126. Give a balanced opinion about whether social media is useful.
127. Respond politely to: Online classes are always better than face-to-face classes.
128. Write one sentence with partial agreement.
129. Write one sentence with strong disagreement but polite tone.

Model lines

- In my view, social media is useful when it is used with clear limits and a critical mindset.
- I can see why some people prefer online classes, but I don't think they are always better because interaction can be weaker.
- I agree up to a point, but cost should not be the only factor.
- I'm afraid I can't agree with that because the evidence points in a different direction.

29. Storytelling and describing experiences

Storytelling is one of the best ways to combine grammar, vocabulary, and fluency. When you tell a story, you naturally practise past tenses, sequencing expressions, descriptive vocabulary, and emotion words. Many Vietnamese learners answer speaking questions with short information only. That is safe, but it does not create memorable, natural English. A short personal story can transform a flat answer into a strong one.

A simple practical story structure is: set the scene, explain what happened, describe the key moment, and end with the result or lesson. You do not need a dramatic story. Everyday stories work well if they are clear and specific.

Speaking principles

- Use time markers to guide the listener: one day, at first, then, a few minutes later, eventually, in the end.
- Mix past simple and past continuous for better narrative flow.
- Add sensory or emotional detail, but only the details that matter.
- Finish with a result, reaction, or lesson. Stories feel incomplete without an ending.

High-value chunks

Function	Natural English
Opening	A few months ago, I had an experience that ...
Background	At the time, I was ...
Sequence	Then/after that/a moment later/eventually ...
Reaction	I was surprised because ...
Outcome	In the end, ...
Lesson	Since then, I've tried to ...

Common speaking mistakes

Common mistake	Better English
Only list events with and and and	Use sequence markers to show the order clearly.
Use present tense for a finished story	Keep a stable past-time frame.
Too many unimportant details	Choose details that support the main event.
No ending or reflection	Add result or lesson.

Practice tasks

130. Tell a story about a time you were late.
131. Describe a useful lesson you learned from a mistake.
132. Tell a short story about a trip or family event.
133. Describe a time when you had to speak English unexpectedly.

Model lines

- A few months ago, I was on my way to an interview when the bus suddenly broke down.
- At the time, I was already feeling nervous, so the delay made the situation even worse.
- In the end, I arrived about ten minutes late, but I explained honestly and the interviewer was understanding.
- Since then, I've tried to leave much earlier for important appointments.

30. Meetings, class discussion, and workplace English

Real-world speaking is often collaborative. You need to suggest ideas, agree on actions, interrupt politely, ask for updates, clarify tasks, and summarise next steps. Many learners know grammar but still feel unprepared in meetings because they do not know the standard chunks that organise professional talk. Once you learn these chunks, speaking becomes much easier and much more confident.

This chapter focuses on practical collaborative English, which is valuable for university work, office meetings, project teams, and online calls.

Speaking principles

- Use signpost phrases to manage turns: Shall we start with ... ? The main point is ... Before we move on ...
- Polite interruption is normal in English meetings when done carefully.
- Summaries and action points are essential: So, we've agreed that ...
- Good workplace speaking combines grammar accuracy with efficiency. Short, clear language often works best.

High-value chunks

Function	Natural English
Starting	Shall we get started?
Suggestion	Why don't we ... ?/We could ...
Clarifying task	Just to confirm, do you want me to ... ?
Polite interruption	Sorry to interrupt, but could I add something here?
Summary	So, the main point is that ...
Next step	I'll take care of ... by Friday.

Common speaking mistakes

Common mistake	Better English
I have an idea, listen me.	I have an idea—could you listen for a moment?/Listen to me for a moment.
We discuss about the budget.	Let's discuss the budget.
I will responsible for this part.	I will be responsible for this part.
Can you feedback me?	Can you give me feedback?

Practice tasks

134. Suggest a meeting time politely.
135. Clarify a task after a class project discussion.
136. Summarise a short decision in one sentence.
137. Interrupt politely to add a new point.

Model lines

- Would 3 p.m. on Thursday work for everyone?
- Just to confirm, would you like me to prepare the slides and send them tonight?
- So, we've agreed to focus on two main issues: cost and customer experience.
- Sorry to interrupt, but I think we should also consider the delivery time.

31. Pronunciation habits that affect grammar and vocabulary

This book focuses on grammar and vocabulary, but speaking accuracy also depends on pronunciation habits. Vietnamese learners often know the correct grammar in writing yet lose meaning in speech because important final sounds disappear. These final sounds often carry grammar: works, worked, wants, asked, bags, booked. If the final sound is unclear, the listener may miss plural meaning, tense, or third person agreement.

Pronunciation also affects vocabulary. Good vocabulary is not useful if the stress pattern is wrong or if key vowel differences make one word sound like another. The practical goal is not perfect accent; it is intelligibility and grammatical clarity.

Speaking principles

- Protect final consonants, especially -s, -z, -t, -d, -k, -p, -f, and consonant clusters at the end of words.
- Practise the three pronunciations of -ed and -s endings.
- Learn word stress with vocabulary: imPORTant, deVELop, ecoNOmic, responSIBle.
- In connected speech, strong grammar words can become weak: to, of, can, for, and. Listen actively for this.

High-value chunks

Function	Natural English
Plural pair	book/books
Tense pair	work/worked
Third-person pair	live/lives
Stress pair	PREsent (noun)/preSENT (verb)
Clarifying speech	Let me say that again more clearly.
Self-repair	Sorry, I mean ...

Common speaking mistakes

Common mistake	Better English
Drop final -s in lives/works	This removes important grammar information.
Pronounce every -ed as /ɪd/	Use /t/, /d/, or /ɪd/ depending on the final sound.

Common mistake	Better English
Equal stress on every syllable	English rhythm needs stressed and unstressed syllables.
Memorise vocabulary without pronunciation	Always learn sound, stress, and example sentence together.

Practice tasks

138. Read aloud five pairs: work/worked, ask/asked, live/lives, need/needed, watch/watches.
139. Mark the stress in ten new words from this book.
140. Record yourself reading one paragraph and listen for missing final sounds.
141. Practise three self-repair phrases.

Model lines

- Possible self-repair: Sorry, let me say that again.
- Possible self-repair: What I mean is that the cost increased gradually.
- Possible self-repair: More specifically, I'm talking about public transport, not private cars.
- Possible observation: I often lose final -s when I speak quickly.

32. Fluency builders and repair strategies

Fluency is not speaking fast. Fluency means keeping the conversation moving even when you need time to think or when a word disappears. Strong speakers use repair strategies automatically. They pause naturally, buy time, rephrase, define a missing word, and check that the listener is following. Many learners feel embarrassed when they get stuck, but getting stuck is normal. The practical difference is how you recover.

Repair language is especially useful for Vietnamese learners because it reduces the pressure to translate exactly. If you cannot remember one word, you can still explain the idea and continue speaking.

Speaking principles

- Use time-gaining phrases instead of silence: Let me think for a second; That's an interesting point.
- Rephrase when a word is missing: It's a kind of ..., It's the place where ..., It means ...
- Signal correction clearly: Sorry, what I mean is ..., Actually, let me rephrase that.
- Fluency grows from repeated speaking on familiar topics, not only from reading grammar rules.

High-value chunks

Function	Natural English
Buying time	Let me think for a moment.
Rephrasing	Another way to say it is ...
Explaining unknown word	It's a kind of .../It's something you use to ...
Correcting yourself	Sorry, I mean ...
Checking listener	Does that make sense?
Closing answer	So overall, that's why I think ...

Common speaking mistakes

Common mistake	Better English
Stop completely when one word is missing	Use a definition, synonym, or example and continue.
Repeat um, um, um for too long	Use a real English holding phrase instead.
Apologise too much	Repair calmly and keep going.
Translate silently for too long	Say the part you know and build the rest around it.

Practice tasks

142. Explain a word you cannot name directly: umbrella, keyboard, traffic jam.
143. Answer a question for forty seconds using one buying-time phrase and one repair phrase.
144. Describe a problem at work without stopping even if you forget one word.
145. Record a one-minute answer and mark where you paused.

Model lines

- It's something you use when it rains and you need to keep yourself dry.
- Let me think for a second. I'd say the main issue is time management.
- Sorry, I mean the deadline, not the schedule.
- Another way to say it is that people want more flexibility.

PART V

Vocabulary mastery

Learn how vocabulary really works: word families, collocations, topic banks, spoken chunks, and formal vocabulary.

33. How to learn vocabulary properly

Vocabulary is more than meaning. To really know a word, you need at least six things: meaning, pronunciation, spelling, grammar pattern, collocations, and register. Many learners write a word with a Vietnamese translation and think the job is done. Later, they recognise the word when reading but cannot use it correctly in speech or writing. Real vocabulary learning is deeper.

For Vietnamese learners, the most practical method is chunk-based learning. Instead of memorising success = thành công, learn achieve success, a successful project, successfully complete a task, and It was a success because ... This creates usable English.

Practical principles

- Learn words with a model sentence from your own life whenever possible.
- Record the grammar pattern: depend on, insist on V-ing, responsible for, interested in, suggest V-ing.
- Record at least one strong collocation for each important word.
- Separate speaking vocabulary from formal writing vocabulary when needed.
- Review actively: cover the English, say it aloud, use it in a sentence, and test the collocation.

Vocabulary table

Learn this	Not only this	Better notebook entry
decide	quyết định	decide to do/make a decision/decisive
advice	lời khuyên	useful advice/give advice/ask for advice
improve	cải thiện	improve your writing/an improvement in/improved dramatically
responsible	chịu trách nhiệm	responsible for/take responsibility for
opportunity	cơ hội	a great opportunity/miss an opportunity/equal opportunity
effective	hiệu quả	an effective method/work effectively/effectiveness

Typical vocabulary mistakes

Problem	Better habit
Memorising single words without patterns	Learn word families and common partners together.
Learning only English -> Vietnamese translation	Add example sentence, collocation, and pronunciation.

Problem	Better habit
Reviewing passively by reading lists	Test yourself actively and say the word aloud.
Using every new word immediately in formal writing	First learn whether the word sounds natural in that register.

Tasks

146. Take five words you learned this week and add one collocation and one personal example to each.
147. Group ten words by topic instead of by alphabetical order.
148. Make two flashcards: one for speaking chunks, one for formal writing phrases.

Model notebook lines/examples

- Possible notebook entry: aware — aware of — become aware of the problem — I became aware of the issue during the meeting.
- Possible notebook entry: flexible — a flexible schedule — work flexibly — online study gives people a more flexible routine.

34. Word families, prefixes, and suffixes

Word families help you expand vocabulary quickly because one root can produce several useful forms. This is powerful for Vietnamese learners who want to improve both speaking and writing. If you know employ, you can also learn employee, employer, employment, unemployment, employable, and self-employed. This creates range without forcing you to memorise unrelated words.

Prefixes and suffixes also help you guess meaning when reading. However, you should still check real usage, because not every form is equally common or natural.

Practical principles

- When you learn a new academic or professional word, ask: what are the noun, verb, adjective, and adverb forms?
- Common noun suffixes: -tion, -sion, -ment, -ness, -ity, -er, -or.
- Common adjective suffixes: -al, -ive, -able, -ible, -ous, -ful, -less.
- Common adverb suffix: -ly. Common negative prefixes: un-, in-, im-, dis-, non-.

Vocabulary table

Root	Useful family	Model use
decide	decision, decisive, indecisive	make a decision/a decisive step
educate	education, educational, educator	education policy/educational value
inform	information, informative, informed	an informative talk/well-informed citizens
develop	development, developer, developing, developmental	economic development
employ	employment, employee, employer, unemployed	youth employment
flex	flexible, inflexible, flexibility	a flexible schedule

Root	Useful family	Model use
responsible	responsibility, irresponsible, responsibly	take responsibility
effect	effective, ineffective, effectively, effectiveness	an effective strategy
communicate	communication, communicative, miscommunication	communication skills
produce	product, production, productive, productivity	increase productivity

Vocabulary table

Affix	Meaning	Example
un-	not/opposite	unfair, unclear, unsafe
re-	again/back	review, rebuild, rewrite
mis-	wrongly/badly	misunderstand, mismanage
-tion	action/result noun	educate → education
-ment	result/state noun	develop → development
-able	capable of/suitable	readable, affordable
-less	without	careless, powerless
-ful	full of	helpful, meaningful

Tasks

149. Choose five roots and build word-family maps.
150. Write one speaking sentence and one writing sentence with two different family members of the same root.
151. Find three negative prefixes in texts you read this week.

Model notebook lines/examples

- Possible pair: communicate — communication. Speaking: Clear communication is important in meetings. Writing: Poor communication can reduce trust.
- Possible pair: flexible — flexibility. Speaking: I need more flexibility in my work schedule. Writing: Flexibility is increasingly valued in modern workplaces.

35. Collocations: the fastest way to sound natural

Collocations are words that naturally go together. English is full of them, and natural speaking or writing depends on them more than on rare vocabulary. Native and advanced speakers do not choose each word separately every time; they often use ready-made partnerships such as make a decision, take responsibility, heavy traffic, strong evidence, deeply disappointed, highly effective, and fully aware.

Vietnamese learners can know the meaning of every single word in a sentence and still sound unnatural because the words are combined in a non-English way. That is why collocation study is one of the highest-value activities you can do.

Practical principles

- Learn verb + noun, adjective + noun, adverb + adjective, noun + noun, and preposition patterns.
- When you notice a useful phrase in reading or listening, record the whole chunk, not only the keyword.
- Collocations are especially important for formal writing and professional speaking.
- Build topic-based collocation banks: education, work, environment, health, technology, travel.

Vocabulary table

Type	Examples	Useful sentence
verb + noun	make a decision, take notes, do research, raise awareness	The campaign aims to raise awareness.
adjective + noun	strong evidence, heavy traffic, practical solution, serious problem	We need a practical solution.
adverb + adjective	highly effective, deeply concerned, closely related	These issues are closely related.
noun + noun	job satisfaction, language barrier, traffic congestion	Traffic congestion wastes time.
verb + preposition	focus on, depend on, result in, contribute to	Noise pollution contributes to stress.
adjective + preposition	afraid of, suitable for, interested in, aware of	This course is suitable for beginners.

Vocabulary table

Wrong combination	Natural English	Why
do a decision	make a decision	English uses make here.
strong rain	heavy rain	Heavy collocates with rain.
big traffic	heavy traffic	Heavy traffic is the standard phrase.
very convenient for me to this schedule	This schedule is convenient for me/This schedule works for me	Convenient has common sentence patterns.
powerful coffee	strong coffee	Strong is the normal collocation.

Tasks

152. Choose one topic and collect ten collocations from articles or videos.
153. Write one short paragraph using at least five collocations from this chapter.
154. Create two columns in your notebook: natural collocation/common wrong translation.

Model notebook lines/examples

- Possible sentence: Better public transport could reduce heavy traffic and improve job satisfaction by shortening the daily commute.
- Possible sentence: Strong evidence suggests that sleep quality is closely related to concentration.

36. Phrasal verbs and multi-word verbs

Phrasal verbs are common in speech and semi-formal writing. Some are transparent, but many have extended meanings that cannot be guessed from the individual words alone. Vietnamese learners often avoid them or use them too literally. You do not need to master hundreds at once, but you should learn the high-frequency ones that appear in work, study, and daily conversation.

A good practical approach is to group phrasal verbs by theme: communication, progress, problems, relationships, work, and organisation.

Practical principles

- Learn phrasal verbs with one clear meaning first and add other meanings later.
- Notice separable and inseparable patterns: turn on the light/turn the light on; look after a child.
- Use phrasal verbs naturally in speaking, but choose carefully in formal writing.
- Many high-value phrasal verbs are common in meetings and study talk: find out, point out, carry out, work on, deal with, come up with.

Vocabulary table

Phrasal verb	Meaning	Example
find out	discover	I found out about the course online.
carry out	perform/conduct	The team carried out a survey.
come up with	think of	We need to come up with a better plan.
deal with	handle	She deals with customer complaints.
point out	highlight	The teacher pointed out two grammar errors.
work on	spend time improving/doing	I'm working on my speaking.
set up	arrange/create	We set up a new study group.
pick up	collect/learn casually	I picked up a few phrases from podcasts.
put off	delay	Don't put off your revision.
run out of	have no more	I ran out of time.

Vocabulary table

Common speaking use	Chunk	Register note
Progress	I'm working on it.	very common spoken English

Common speaking use	Chunk	Register note
Discovery	I found out that ...	neutral
Handling	We need to deal with this soon.	neutral/formal enough
Idea	We came up with three options.	common in meetings
Delay	Let's put it off until Friday.	informal to neutral

Tasks

155. Choose five phrasal verbs and create work/study examples.
156. Rewrite one formal sentence with a more spoken phrasal-verb alternative where appropriate.
157. Practise separable forms aloud: turn on the light/turn the light on.

Model notebook lines/examples

- Possible sentence: I'm working on my pronunciation, especially final sounds.
- Possible sentence: Our group came up with a practical way to share notes after class.

37. Formal vocabulary for writing and natural vocabulary for speaking

Not every useful word belongs in every situation. Writing often needs neutral or formal vocabulary, while speaking often sounds better with shorter, more everyday choices. Strong learners recognise both options and choose based on context. The goal is not to avoid simple words; simple words are often the clearest. The goal is to know when you need something more formal and when you do not.

This distinction is especially useful for Vietnamese learners preparing for work, study, presentations, or exams. You can keep the meaning the same while adjusting the tone.

Practical principles

- Formal writing often prefers verbs like reduce, increase, encourage, discourage, require, demonstrate, indicate, contribute to, and result in.
- Natural speaking often prefers shorter everyday choices like cut down, go up, help, show, point out, bring about, and lead to.
- Some formal words sound unnatural in casual speech if used too often. Some very casual words sound weak in writing.
- Build pairs: ask/inquire, buy/purchase, help/assist, start/begin/commence, fix/resolve, get/obtain/receive.

Vocabulary table

Everyday/spoken	Neutral or formal writing	Example
help	assist/support	The programme supports low-income families.
show	demonstrate/indicate	The data indicate a clear increase.
go up	increase/rise	Housing costs have risen sharply.

Everyday/spoken	Neutral or formal writing	Example
go down	decrease/decline	Interest declined slightly.
cause	lead to/result in/contribute to	Poor sleep can lead to stress.
fix	resolve/address	The policy aims to address this issue.
a lot of	a significant amount of/many	A significant number of students ...
big	major/significant/substantial	a major challenge
good	effective/beneficial/favourable	an effective method
bad	harmful/negative/damaging	negative consequences

Tasks

158. Rewrite a casual paragraph in a more formal style.
159. Rewrite a formal paragraph in a more natural spoken style.
160. Choose five overused adjectives (good, bad, big, small, important) and build alternatives by topic.

Model notebook lines/examples

- Spoken: This app helps me organise my time. Written: This application helps users manage their time more effectively.
- Spoken: Prices went up fast. Written: Prices rose rapidly.

38. False friends and direct-translation traps for Vietnamese learners

Some English errors are not grammar errors; they are translation traps. The sentence is understandable, but it is not natural English. These traps are especially common among Vietnamese learners because the Vietnamese expression feels logical. If you want practical improvement, this chapter may save you more time than learning twenty rare words.

Treat these items as memory pairs: wrong habit -> natural English. Review them often, because direct translation habits are stubborn.

Practical principles

- Do not translate every Vietnamese phrase word by word.
- When an expression feels strange, check whether English uses a chunk instead of a literal translation.
- Record traps that you personally use often.
- Listen for natural alternatives in real conversations and podcasts.

Vocabulary table

Common trap	Natural English	Note
open the light/close the light	turn on the light/turn off the light	English uses turn on/off.

Common trap	Natural English	Note
borrow me your pen	lend me your pen	Borrow = take from; lend = give temporarily.
very delicious	delicious/really good	Delicious already carries strong meaning.
learn knowledge	gain knowledge/learn something	Knowledge is usually gained or acquired.
discuss about	discuss	No about after discuss.
until now I still ...	I still .../Up to now, I have ...	Choose a natural English time pattern.
make exercise	do exercise/do exercises	Do is the usual verb.
one time/two times	once/twice	Use once/twice where possible.
have free	be free/have some free time	Natural chunk differs.
convenient for me	works for me/is convenient for me	Context matters.
send for me	send it to me	Use natural preposition pattern.
feedback me	give me feedback	Feedback is a noun in common use.
same same	similar/the same	Avoid nonstandard informal forms.
my English level is not high	my English level is not very strong/my English isn't very strong yet	Natural phrasing varies by context.

Tasks

161. Choose ten traps you have used before and write a correct sentence for each.
162. Listen to one English podcast and note natural chunks that replace direct translation habits.
163. Create a personal 'wrong but common' list on your phone for daily review.

Model notebook lines/examples

- Possible sentence: Could you lend me your charger for a minute?
- Possible sentence: I still find public speaking difficult, but I'm improving.
- Possible sentence: This time works for me.

39. Topic bank: personal introduction, personality, and relationships

Use these chunks to talk about yourself, describe people, and build natural speaking answers or short descriptive paragraphs.

Word/chunk	Meaning/use	Example
outgoing	friendly and comfortable with people	She is quite outgoing and makes friends easily.
reserved	quiet and not very expressive at first	I can seem reserved when I meet new people.
reliable	can be trusted to do what is needed	My closest friend is reliable and calm under pressure.
open-minded	willing to consider different ideas	Studying abroad helped him become more open-minded.
close-knit family	family with strong relationships	I come from a close-knit family in central Vietnam.
get along with	have a good relationship with	I get along well with my colleagues.
have a lot in common	share interests or traits	We became close because we had a lot in common.
look up to	admire and respect	I look up to my older sister because she is disciplined.
supportive	kind and helpful emotionally or practically	My parents have always been supportive of my choices.
independent	able to act without relying too much on others	Living away from home made me more independent.
easy-going	relaxed and not easily upset	Our supervisor is strict but surprisingly easy-going.
keep in touch	continue communicating	I still keep in touch with my high-school classmates.
first impression	initial opinion of someone	My first impression was that he was very confident.
sense of humour	ability to notice and express what is funny	A good sense of humour makes conversations easier.
deal with conflict	handle disagreements	She deals with conflict in a calm and respectful way.

Useful speaking frames

- I'd describe myself as ..., especially when ...
- What I value most in a friend is ... because ...
- I come from a ..., so I learned early to ...

Useful writing frames

- One personal quality that has helped me most is ...
- A supportive environment can have a strong effect on ...

40. Topic bank: study, learning, and education

These words and chunks are high-value for school, university, professional development, and educational writing.

Word/chunk	Meaning/use	Example
revise regularly	review material many times	Students who revise regularly usually feel less stressed before exams.
meet a deadline	finish before the required time	I sometimes struggle to meet deadlines when I plan poorly.
fall behind	fail to keep up with work	If I miss one class, I can fall behind quickly.
take notes	write key information while listening or reading	I prefer to take notes by hand.
pay attention	focus carefully	It is hard to pay attention when the room is noisy.
hands-on learning	learning by doing practical tasks	Hands-on learning is more memorable for many students.
critical thinking	careful analysis and evaluation	University should develop critical thinking, not just memorisation.
learning curve	rate at which a skill is learned	The software has a steep learning curve.
feedback	comments that help improvement	Regular feedback helps learners improve faster.
self-discipline	ability to control yourself and stay on task	Online learning requires a high level of self-discipline.
practical skills	skills that can be used directly in real situations	Many employers care about practical skills.

Word/chunk	Meaning/use	Example
broaden your horizons	expand knowledge and experience	Travel and reading can broaden your horizons.
struggle with	find something difficult	Many beginners struggle with article use.
grasp a concept	understand an idea clearly	It took me a while to grasp the concept.
knowledge gap	missing knowledge in an area	The course helped me close a major knowledge gap.

Useful speaking frames

- One study habit that works well for me is ...
- The biggest challenge in learning English is ... because ...
- I've improved most since I started to ...

Useful writing frames

- An effective education system should ...
- One major challenge students face is ...

41. Topic bank: work, career, and business

Use these items for interviews, workplace conversation, presentations, and formal writing about employment or business topics.

Word/chunk	Meaning/use	Example
workload	amount of work	My workload is heavy at the end of each month.
job satisfaction	how happy someone is with their job	Flexible hours can improve job satisfaction.
career path	long-term direction of a career	I'm still figuring out my career path.
take responsibility	accept duty for something	Good employees take responsibility for mistakes.
meet expectations	perform at the required level	The new system did not meet expectations.
teamwork	working effectively with others	Teamwork is essential in project-based jobs.
time management	organising time well	Time management is one of the skills I want to strengthen.

Word/chunk	Meaning/use	Example
problem-solving	finding solutions to difficulties	The role requires strong problem-solving skills.
professional development	improving work-related skills	The company supports professional development.
work-life balance	balance between job and personal life	Remote work can improve work-life balance for some people.
promotion	move to a higher position	She earned a promotion after leading a successful campaign.
competitive salary	good salary compared with others	A competitive salary attracts skilled workers.
work under pressure	perform well in stressful conditions	I can work under pressure when I prepare in advance.
customer satisfaction	how happy customers are	Customer satisfaction dropped after delivery delays.
long-term goal	goal for the future	One of my long-term goals is to manage my own team.

Useful speaking frames

- What I'm looking for in a job is ...
- A skill that matters in my field is ... because ...
- In my experience, teamwork works best when ...

Useful writing frames

- Employers increasingly value ...
- A healthy workplace should provide ...

42. Topic bank: daily routine, time, and habits

These chunks help you speak naturally about ordinary life, routines, productivity, and habits.

Word/chunk	Meaning/use	Example
get up early	wake early	I try to get up early on weekdays.
be short on time	not have enough time	I'm short on time in the morning.
stick to a routine	follow a regular pattern	It is easier to study when you stick to a routine.
put something off	delay it	I used to put off difficult tasks.

Word/chunk	Meaning/use	Example
lose track of time	stop noticing time passing	I often lose track of time when I'm reading.
fit something in	find time for it	I fit a short walk into my lunch break.
wind down	relax before rest	I usually wind down by listening to music.
productive	getting useful work done	My most productive hours are early in the morning.
drained	very tired	After long meetings, I feel mentally drained.
stay focused	keep attention on one task	Turning off notifications helps me stay focused.
healthy habit	regular behaviour that benefits health	Drinking more water is a simple healthy habit.
break a habit	stop a repeated behaviour	It takes time to break a bad habit.
build consistency	make behaviour regular and stable	Small goals help you build consistency.
set priorities	decide what matters most	At work I need to set priorities carefully.
make time for	reserve time	I always try to make time for my family.

Useful speaking frames

- On a typical weekday, I ...
- One habit I'm trying to build is ...
- I'm most productive when ...

Useful writing frames

- Daily habits can strongly influence ...
- A consistent routine often leads to ...

43. Topic bank: travel, places, city life, and transport

This bank is useful for speaking about your hometown, travelling, traffic, tourism, and urban life.

Word/chunk	Meaning/use	Example
public transport	buses, trains, metro systems	Public transport is improving slowly in my city.
traffic congestion	heavy traffic that causes delays	Traffic congestion is worst during rush hour.
commute	travel regularly between home and work/study	My daily commute takes about forty minutes.
walkable	easy to move around on foot	The old town is surprisingly walkable.
scenic	beautiful in a natural way	We drove along a scenic coastal road.
landmark	famous place or structure	The bridge has become a landmark in the city.
off the beaten track	away from the usual tourist areas	I prefer places that are a bit off the beaten track.
breathtaking	extremely beautiful	The view from the hill was breathtaking.
conveniently located	in a practical position	The hotel is conveniently located near the station.
crowded	full of people	The beach gets crowded on public holidays.
laid-back atmosphere	relaxed feeling	The town has a laid-back atmosphere.
local cuisine	food from a specific area	Trying the local cuisine is part of the travel experience.
make your way to	go toward a place	We made our way to the harbour before sunrise.
reliable service	transport or system that works consistently	People need reliable public transport.
urban sprawl	city expansion over a wide area	Urban sprawl can increase commuting times.

Useful speaking frames

- What I like most about my city is ...
- One transport problem where I live is ...
- When I travel, I usually look for ...

Useful writing frames

- Urban areas often struggle with ...
- Tourism can benefit a city by ...

44. Topic bank: food, health, and lifestyle

Use these chunks when speaking about habits, health choices, food preferences, and social issues related to lifestyle.

Word/chunk	Meaning/use	Example
balanced diet	healthy mix of foods	A balanced diet is harder to maintain during busy weeks.
processed food	food altered industrially, often less healthy	Many people rely too much on processed food.
home-cooked meal	meal prepared at home	I prefer home-cooked meals because they feel healthier.
portion size	amount of food served	Portion size affects how much people eat.
get enough sleep	sleep an adequate amount	I perform badly when I don't get enough sleep.
sedentary lifestyle	life with too little physical movement	Office workers often struggle with a sedentary lifestyle.
stay hydrated	drink enough water	It's easy to forget to stay hydrated in hot weather.
mental well-being	healthy emotional and mental state	Exercise can improve mental well-being.
cut down on	reduce	I'm trying to cut down on sugar.
work out	exercise	I work out three times a week when my schedule allows.
cope with stress	handle pressure	Some people cope with stress by walking or journaling.
immune system	body's defence system	Sleep plays an important role in the immune system.
lifestyle choice	decision about how to live	Smoking is a harmful lifestyle choice.
long-term health	health over many years	Diet affects long-term health, not just weight.
maintain a healthy routine	keep good habits consistently	It is difficult to maintain a healthy routine during exam season.

Useful speaking frames

- A healthy habit I'm trying to maintain is ...
- When I'm stressed, I usually ...
- I prefer ... because ...

Useful writing frames

- Public health campaigns should encourage ...
- Modern lifestyles often make it harder to ...

45. Topic bank: technology, media, and the internet

These terms help you discuss phones, apps, social media, digital learning, privacy, and modern communication.

Word/chunk	Meaning/use	Example
digital literacy	ability to use digital tools effectively	Digital literacy is now essential in most jobs.
screen time	time spent looking at screens	I try to limit my screen time before bed.
online platform	website/app used for interaction or services	Our course materials are on an online platform.
reliable source	trustworthy information source	Students need to identify reliable sources online.
misinformation	false or misleading information	Social media can spread misinformation quickly.
data privacy	protection of personal information	Many users worry about data privacy.
user-friendly	easy to use	The app is user-friendly even for beginners.
digital distraction	technology that interrupts focus	Notifications are a constant digital distraction.
remote collaboration	working together from different places	Remote collaboration requires clear communication.
technical issue	problem with technology	We had a technical issue during the online meeting.
upload/download	send to/take from the internet	Please upload the file before noon.
go viral	spread very quickly online	The video went viral overnight.

Word/chunk	Meaning/use	Example
content creator	person who makes online content	Some students want to become content creators.
algorithm	system that controls what users see	The platform's algorithm shapes what people watch.
digital footprint	record of online activity	Young people should understand their digital footprint.

Useful speaking frames

- One useful app I use regularly is ...
- A problem with social media is ...
- Technology has changed the way I ...

Useful writing frames

- Digital tools can improve ... but they may also ...
- One concern related to technology is ...

46. Topic bank: environment, society, and public issues

This set is useful for formal writing, discussions about policy, and everyday conversations about public problems.

Word/chunk	Meaning/use	Example
climate change	long-term global environmental change	Climate change is already affecting weather patterns.
air pollution	harmful pollution in the air	Air pollution is a serious problem in many cities.
renewable energy	energy from sources that naturally continue	Renewable energy is becoming more affordable.
waste management	handling rubbish and recycling	Waste management needs better planning.
public awareness	what the public knows about an issue	Campaigns can raise public awareness.
household income	money earned by a family	Higher transport costs affect low-income households most.
social inequality	unfair differences in wealth or opportunity	Education can reduce social inequality over time.
access to healthcare	ability to receive medical services	Rural areas often have weaker access to healthcare.

Word/chunk	Meaning/use	Example
affordable housing	housing that people can reasonably pay for	Affordable housing is a major urban issue.
community support	help from local people or organisations	Strong community support can improve resilience.
public policy	government plan or rule	Public policy should be based on evidence.
long-term impact	effect over time	We need to consider the long-term impact of this decision.
sustainable development	growth that protects future needs	Cities need more sustainable development strategies.
social pressure	pressure from other people or society	Young people often face social pressure online.
quality of life	overall comfort and well-being in life	Green spaces can improve quality of life.

Useful speaking frames

- One issue in my area that worries me is ...
- I think governments should ...
- The long-term impact could be ...

Useful writing frames

- This issue has both environmental and social consequences.
- A sustainable solution should ...

47. Topic bank: culture, entertainment, and opinions

Use these items for conversations about films, music, traditions, free time, and personal viewpoints.

Word/chunk	Meaning/use	Example
cultural identity	sense of belonging to a culture	Language plays a big role in cultural identity.
traditional values	older cultural beliefs and habits	Some traditional values remain strong in my family.
keep a tradition alive	continue a custom	Festivals help keep a tradition alive.
be into	be interested in	I'm really into documentaries these days.

Word/chunk	Meaning/use	Example
catchy	easy to remember, especially music	The song is simple but very catchy.
thought-provoking	making you think deeply	It was a thought-provoking film about technology.
overrated	more praised than deserved	Some famous tourist spots feel overrated.
underrated	better than people realise	Local museums are often underrated.
leisure time	free time	I try to use my leisure time more actively.
unwind	relax after stress	Music helps me unwind after work.
relate to	feel a connection with	I could really relate to the main character.
broaden perspective	expand understanding of different views	Travel can broaden your perspective.
social event	planned gathering of people	Community festivals are important social events.
form an opinion	develop a view	It's easy to form an opinion without enough information.
personal taste	individual preference	A lot of this comes down to personal taste.

Useful speaking frames

- A film or book that affected me was ... because ...
- One tradition I value is ...
- In my opinion, this trend is overrated/underrated because ...

Useful writing frames

- Cultural events can strengthen ...
- Entertainment is valuable not only because ... but also because ...

48. Topic bank: describing change, comparison, and data

These words are useful for reports, presentations, and any writing that describes trends, quantities, and comparisons.

Word/chunk	Meaning/use	Example
increase sharply	rise quickly and strongly	Sales increased sharply in the final quarter.
rise steadily	go up gradually and consistently	The number rose steadily over the period.
decline slightly	go down a little	Interest declined slightly after May.
remain stable	stay almost the same	Costs remained stable for three years.
peak at	reach the highest point	The figure peaked at 75 percent.
drop to	fall to a level	The rate dropped to 12 percent.
account for	make up a part of the total	Women accounted for just over half of respondents.
the majority/minority	most/smaller part	The majority supported the change.
roughly the same as	nearly equal to	The two figures were roughly the same.
significant difference	important difference	There was a significant difference between the groups.
widen the gap	make a difference bigger	The policy may widen the gap between rich and poor.
narrow the gap	make a difference smaller	Training can narrow the skills gap.
by contrast	in comparison with something different	By contrast, the rural figure remained low.
overall trend	general pattern	The overall trend was upward.
fluctuate	go up and down irregularly	Prices fluctuated throughout the year.

Useful speaking frames

- Overall, the main trend is ...
- The biggest difference is that ...
- Compared with ..., ... is ...

Useful writing frames

• Overall, it is clear that ...
• By contrast, the figure for ... remained ...

Final advice

Keep this simple rule in mind

• Do not try to fix everything in one week. Consistent correction of repeated errors is more powerful than short periods of intense study.
• When you learn new vocabulary, learn the pattern and the pronunciation at the same time.
• Use English every day in small ways: short messages, mini summaries, voice notes, questions, and corrections.
• The best learners do three things repeatedly: notice, use, and review.